

Films of 2023



Rules: 1) Almost always be (primarily) English language, 2) Must be a non-documentary feature. Sorry, otherwise this list gets another 20+ films added and I do not have that much time. 3) US Theatrical(-ish) release in 2023 (some of these films might have IMDb years for earlier due to film festival releases, or a 2022 Australian release before a 2023 US release. Also Covid resulted in films getting a delayed release). This year US theatrical-ish release has been pushed to its limits; some films with early 2023 releases – but a 2022 film festival showing – that were 2022 award eligible, are counted as 2022 and therefore are not included in this list. With the rise of (direct-to-) streaming, multiple awards have a TV or Streaming Movie Category. When applicable these films are included as well.

Within a tier, I believe the films are roughly the same quality. Between tiers, I believe there is enough distinction to say a film is better than those in the lower tier. Although, that distinction is blurrier for films at the bottom of a tier and the films at the top of the previous tier.

Selection Criteria: 1) Oscar Nominated, 2) Golden Globe Nominated, 3) Independent Spirit Awards, 4) BAFTA, 5) GLAAD Awards, 6) Black Reel Awards (replacing NAACP Image), 7) AACTA Awards (Australian Oscars) 8) Sundance, 9) Guild Awards: SAG, DGA, PGA, ACE, and ASC, 10) AFI Top 10, 11) National Board of Review, 12) Critic's Choice Awards, 13) British Independent Film Awards, 14) Annie Awards, 15) My own idiosyncratic preferences, 16) Some heterogeneous-minimum Rotten Tomatoes score regardless if nominated. Note: These are not necessarily the ranking of a criterion's importance.

[A selection criterion is in brackets to give an idea of why the film was on my list; award nominations are given preference, but also my own idiosyncratic reasons for watching, when applicable. Films were on the list before awards seasons, but the nominations/awards reflect that these did end up being good films.].

Streaming service is up-to-date as of **5/26/24**; afterwards who knows. So watch them now. I only included without-ads services. I did not include 'free' streaming with a cable add-on (Starz, Showtime, etc). Many of these can be rented on streaming services, but the ability to rent was not included.

Tier 15: It Won the Golden Raspberry for a Reason

195. **Winnie-the-Pooh: Blood and Honey:** No. Just don't. This might be the worst movie of all time. It isn't even campy fun. There are no laughs, there are no scares, and the kills are lame. The acting is some of the worst you'll see in your life. There is no fun to be had. Do not watch this. [Horribly-reviewed Horror], *Peacock*.

Tier 14: Bad Wide-Releases and One I Have No Idea How It Got On The List

194. **Don't Look Away:** I have no idea how the film ended up on the list; it has only eight reviews on Rotten Tomatoes with a 62. The 62 is generous and the visuals on the low budget are decent. However the horror isn't scary. You have to wonder if the actors are even professionals as the delivery of lines is always flat. The film forces homages to everything from *The Shining* to *Don't Breathe* but offers little new. The script is awful, 'I'm a PhD candidate. I know more than you'll ever comprehend' is an actual line of dialogue. [A Horror that Somehow I Watched].
193. **Five Nights at Freddy's:** Few things are worse than a 'horror' that isn't scary (that the film is PG-13 helped the box office but not the quality). The film also shoehorns in a plot that is beyond predictable. The major twist is obvious. The final character 'development' is beyond obvious. Apparently the film incorporated some of the franchise's lore, but almost none of its game play feel. Instead of watching this atrocity just watch *Willy's Wonderland*. [Poorly-reviewed Horror], *Amazon Prime*.
192. **Vacation Friends 2:** Quite literally going to copy my review of the first one, with additional comments in italics: The film is rather funny, at times. John Cena is putting together a fun career. The primary issue is that the film can't keep up its initial frantic pace *from the first film*, and the jokes start missing *right away*. The predictable plot isn't much of an issue *as Steve Buscemi makes an appearance*, the film ranks this low because the jokes run out *and never really get started*. [Sequel], *Hulu*.
191. **The Marvels:** Each year I try to outsource one review to a review that perfectly captured my feelings: <https://www.reelviews.net/reelviews/marvels-the>. 'The movie is incomprehensible in its own right and no amount of homework is going to change that... There's minimal chemistry among the three leads. The allegedly serious/sentimental moments are mawkish and cringe-worthy. The acting is generally subpar, including that from Brie Larson... The fight scenes and special effects-laden sequences are so badly choreographed and edited that it can be difficult to figure out what's going on... Instead of offering engaging storytelling, it give us flashes, bangs, bad dialogue, and a mountain of fakery'. [Critic's Choice Super Awards – Best Actress in a Superhero Movie Nominee], *Disney+*.
190. **65:** My (relatively) low-ranking of *A Quiet Place* is starting to look a lot more justified. The film is written and directed by the writing team behind *A Quiet Place*. And this one falls into similar traps; reliance of kid-based sentimentality and weak characters. This film manages to waste Adam Driver of all people. The film also treats the audience like kids as there is a literal title card of "Earth 65 Million Years Ago" as the audience was never gonna be able to figure that one out based on the name and the dinosaurs. Speaking of dinosaurs, they looked bad (not even mentioning that they didn't have feathers!), and some aren't even real dinosaurs!. I also wonder what all of the carnivorous dinos ate as all but one dinosaur interaction is with a Sharptooth. For a film with a budget of over 40 million and a cast of four (two of which are kids aimed at created sentimentality!) it baffles me that they spent the money on dinosaurs which ended up looking that bad. The movie is a complete miss. [Adam Driver], *Netflix*.

189. **Flamin' Hot:** The film has little interest in being a film. Instead it wants to be a straight-forward rags-to-riches story where characters are clichés. The frequent voice overs do not work, at all. Jessie Garcia overdoes it in the leading role. Dennis Haysbert (24) is decent, but again the characters are always paper-thin; the same can be said about Tony Shalhoub (*Marvelous Mrs Maisel*). Few of the jokes land, and it keeps the racism Latinos faced front-and-center. It also worth noting that the inspirational true story is potentially false. The only decent parts about how the economic downturn in the early-90s was a policy and that people deserve their SNAP benefits if eligible. The ending song is kinda good though. [Oscars – Best Original Song Nominee], *Hulu*.
188. **Haunted Mansion:** A perfect example that what you start with matters. Written by Katie Dippold (*Ghostbusters* (2016) and *Snatched*; I've seen neither but the reviews aren't exactly good for either) and directed by Justin Simien (*Dear White People* and *Bad Hair*; both of which I saw, and both of which I ranked low) their combined forces wastes a talented cast who I assume enjoyed when the check was deposited; LaKeith Stanfield, Tiffany Haddish, Owen Wilson, and Danny DeVito all weren't funny! It takes a special collection of awful writing and directing to have that happen. Even if we ignore that a PG-13, family-friendly *horror movie* is always going to have a hard time working, it should be at least funny when you want to write a funny script. This was a complete by-the-numbers miss and I am glad it lost millions. [Poorly-reviewed Horror], *Disney+*.
187. **The Marsh King's Daughter:** An easy way to get placed in these bottom tiers is to be a thriller that isn't thrilling. Daisy Ridley (*Star Wars: The Force Awakens*) and Ben Mendelsohn (*Rogue One*) should combine for a good movie, but the script never builds much real suspense. And worst of all there is a film about childhood trauma to be made here, yet the script only is cursorily interested in exploring that idea. The cinematography doesn't make enough use of the wilderness, and likewise the editing does not add to the tension. It is a miss all around. [Daisy Ridley]

Tier 13: Not Good Wide-Releases, Prestige Flops, and Avoidable Indies

186. **It's a Wonderful Knife:** A Christmas-themed horror-comedy that is neither funny nor scary. Almost none of the jokes land. Whatever voice Jake Long does is bad, and any intelligent director would have axed that instantly. Joel McHale is in it, but given almost nothing to do. A cast of funny people ends up not being funny. Some of the younger actors were tolerable: Jane Widdop and Jess McLeod. Overall the film is a flop, which is sad as screenwriter Michael Kennedy (*Freaky*) has done good work before. [GLAAD – Best Wide Release Nominee]
185. **Next Goal Wins:** Co-written and directed by Taika Waititi (*JoJo Rabbit*) with Michael Fassbender (*Shame*) in the leading role, the film should have been fun feel-good story about a rag-tag soccer team. Instead, the script is rarely funny, characters are not developed, there is little essence of team-building. There was a real-life trans player on the team, and although the script kept the idea, it was not explored beyond a surface level. The entire thing was a miss and it is almost certainly because of Waititi's choices. [Taika Waititi], *Hulu*.
184. **Seriously Red:** I love a good Dolly Parton tribute, so I ignore the poor reviews. Turns out the three good things were: Dolly Parton tribute, Rose Byrne as an Elvis impersonator, and Bobby Cannavale as a Neil Diamond impersonator. The script itself is not that interested in character development or being a study in identity, as the developments are never thought out. Only a few of the jokes land. But it is 94 minutes and features multiple Dolly Parton songs so you wont go crazy watching it. [AACTA – Best Sound Nominee], *Peacock*.
183. **The Pod Generation:** The outline of the film is presumably how it attracted both Emilia Clarke and Chiwetel Ejiofor (*12 Years a Slave*) (who are the only god things about the movie and without them it is the lower tier). Within the first thirty minutes there are eight different speeches about

how hard childbirth is hard for women; it makes you wonder who the film is for—this fact should be obvious and for those that don't know saying it once or twice is enough. The entire blame for the film failing falls squarely on writer-director Sophie Barthes. The themes are in-your-face and not that deep. There are perhaps three genuinely good moments in the film. Rosalie Craig overacts in essentially every scene she is in (all while playing a character that needed to be a few separate characters). It ruins a great premise – the creation, but shortage, of artificial wombs – and wastes it on shallow and childish thematic developments. [Sundance – Sloan Winner], *Hulu*.

182. **When You Finish Saving the World:** Written and directed by Jesse Eisenberg in his first directorial effort. Here all of the flaws are a result of a poor script that writes two of the most annoying characters ever (are are played by Julianne Moore and Finn Wolfhard). The two characters are too grating that the overall themes and acting quality are overshadowed and the viewer simply wishes the two leads would get off the screen. And it is okay to have annoying characters, but their annoying qualities never amount to satire nor does any normal person act the way they do. The writing just does not work. Also for a film 'set' in Bloomington, IN it is not shot in Bloomington, but this is a very me-specific criticism (Eisenberg's wife attended Indiana University). [Jesse Eisenberg]
181. **80 for Brady:** The only reason to watch the film is the four leading ladies: Lily Tomlin, Jane Fonda, Sally Field, and Rita Moreno. Each is able to frequently shine (Sally Field might have been the best; partially because she played the character with the most development). The script is laughably bad; it is absurdest yet frequently not funny (it was co-written by one of the writers of *Booksmart!*). The plot is roughly non-existent, along with the character development. But with living legends it can at least salvage enough to rank here. [Great Cast], *Amazon Prime*.
180. **Wish:** A massive miss by Disney in an attempt to celebrate the company's 100th anniversary. The film often forces references to previous Disney films (and reminds the viewer they could be watching those). The budget was apparently 200 million, but looks bad; the backgrounds appear to be hand-drawn (and inferior to multiple animes on this list) while relying on computer animation for the characters. The combination looks poor (or maybe the computer animation tries an uncanny valley when it comes to movement; the whole film looks bad, one of the selling points of the big budget Disney /Pixar films is that regardless of the poor script the animation looked good). The songs are forgettable. The voice acting is mediocre; dare I suggest Ariana DeBose phoned in her role? Alan Tudyk continues his lengthy string of good voice performances and is the best part of the film as a talking goat. [Critic's Choice Awards – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Disney+*.
179. **Miguel Wants to Fight:** Few things are worse than an unfunny comedy. And this is an unfunny comedy. Too many jokes are not funny. Far too many jokes rely on pop culture references; the film frequently substitutes plot for references; hoping that your love of the classic fight films distracts you from a weak script. Suraj Partha is the best of the gang of young actors, but the others do not stand out. Although being set and filmed in Syracuse, it rarely takes full advantage of its local setting (it rarely takes advantage of anything). The brief script relies on some lazy adages to get the ball rolling; Miguel is given a week's notice they are moving (because the mom will make more money in Albany; which Syracuse has far better nursing opportunities and the Dad owns(?) operates a boxing gym that he is instantly able to sell(?) giveaway?; none of this is clear and a cheap set up for the film). Though thankfully it is 75 minutes. As a twenty-minute unfunny idea being stretched to seventy minutes is far better than stretching it to 105 minutes. [Shea and netw3rk], *Hulu*.
178. **Ant-Man and the Wasp: Quantumania:** This was not a good year for the MCU, which is adrift. The main reason the film works is Jonathan Majors (*Last Black Man in San Francisco*), but given his domestic abuse conviction he is out of the MCU (and this film was meant to reboot the universe with his character as the new main villain). A film that cost over 300 million dollars has never looked so bad; the sound stages are bad, the effects are bad, almost nothing about the film is good. It lacks

a lot of the whimsy that made the first *Ant-Mans* tolerable/enjoyable. William Jackson Harper and Katy O'Brian's characters were of interest but little is done with them. Kathryn Newton (*Freaky*) overacts and forces being a teenager. [*Ant-Man* franchise], *Disney+*.

177. **Peter Pan & Wendy:** The definition of a film that exists. The visual effects are mediocre most of the time, with a few instances of them looking bad (all involving Tinkerbell look bad). Some of the costumes look good. Neither Alexander Molony nor Ever Anderson are talented enough to carry the film (always a risk with young actors; both were under 16 during filming). Jim Gaffigan is not allowed to shine as Mr Smee. David Lowery (*A Ghost Story*) tries to impart some nice camera work, but even he can't save this film. [Live-action Disney], *Disney+*.
176. **Renfield:** One gets the impression the filmmakers assumed a cast of Nic Cage, Nicholas Hoult, Akwafina, and Ben Schwartz would make the film funny. Yet although the premise is funny – Dracula's assistant wants to get out from Dracula's shadow and do good – the script itself is not funny. There are very few laughs in a film with four great comedic actors. The pitch seemed to never get past, "what if Nic Cage played Dracula?". The lighting is rather bad with every-other scene coated in a fake green light. The film tries to be camp with its fight scenes, and they almost work; except the film as a whole is not good. Also, and this is partially a pet peeve, the film is set in New Orleans but the film does not really embrace the city as a character (it is the NOPD, not PDNO). [Nic Cage Plays Dracula], *Amazon Prime*.
175. **Run Rabbit Run:** Sarah Snook (*Predestination*) is good. Lily LaTorre as the young daughter is good. The cinematography is good. And that is the end of the compliments. The script is awful. The film falls into multiple horror tropes within the first fifteen minutes and the film never recovers. It desperately wants to be a *Babadook* clone, but it is a clone that you lock in the basement and never let anyone see. The film is not scary, nor is it a high-concept deconstructionist horror. [AACTA Best Actress – Nominee], *Netflix*.
174. **Golda:** A biopic about Israeli Prime Minister Golda Meir, that made sure the audience knew she was a chain-smoker. There is almost zero character development, and it seems like the real-life Golda was a complex character. Instead the film is a pseudo-documentary detailing the events of the Yom Kippur War. The decision to not show the fighting saved money (radio transmissions from the front lines are the main means conveying the war to the government officials and military leaders) but does lead to a sense of detachment (even if the director might of wanted the detachment it doesn't come through as the script is clear that Golda kept track of the dead each day). Helen Mirren is decent, but isn't given much to work with. The transformation of Mirren to Golda is decent, but not exactly worth the Oscar nomination on its own. [Oscars – Best Hair and Makeup Nominee].
173. **Cat Person:** The film is not much of a thriller, and also not that funny. Emilia Jones (*CODA*) isn't given a chance to shine. Neither is Geraldine Viswanathan (*7 Days*). Both are great actresses and they are given nothing to work with. The script itself is a bit all over the place; the 'dream' sequences do not exactly work, nor do the inner-monologue sequences. Too much of the film is a fail. (Not to mention that although set in New Jersey, they allegedly shop at Kroger.) I have not read the short story which the film is based on, but it seems they stretched themselves too thin, all while losing the thrilling complexities. [Emilia Jones], *Hulu*.
172. **Foe:** The prestige picture that flopped. Saoirse Ronan *Little Women* and Paul Mescal (*Aftersun*) are both decent but have under-developed characters to portray. Aaron Pierre is not good; almost to the point where he actively ruins any scene he is in; neither he nor the director figured out the purpose of his character. However, the biggest sin the film commits is not trusting its audience. The film starts with title cards explaining the science-fiction; the audience knows instantly where the film is going. There is little-to-mystery. It also doesn't help that the director (Garth Davis) is unable to impart a distinct visual style to keep the film engaging while the plot bogs down and drags. There

was a good movie to be made here, but it required an elite director. [Mescal and Ronan], *Amazon Prime*.

171. **Finestkind:** The film suffers from wanting to be a prestige picture, but completely missing, uh, the boat. Written by Oscar-winner Brian Helgeland, the script itself contains some poor dialogue, minimal backstory, and a nonsensical final half. The actors go in-and-out of a Boston accent; and when they have one it is often forced and iffy at best. There were far too many ideas floating around and none of them come together' e.g., the film starts with a fishing boat sinking. Later a character claims it is because the large company didn't maintain the ship (at least the corporate vs family fishing isn't super upfront), but nothing in the first ten minutes shows the poor maintenance. Likewise after the ship sinks, the younger brother supposedly forms an inseparable bond with the crew, but all that is shown is a brief moment or two on a life raft. Once the drugs get introduced the film has lost the plot. At best Jenna Ortega and Tommy Lee Jones are decent. [Critic's Choice – Best TV Movie Nominee], *Paramount+*.
170. **War Pony:** Good reviews be damned, this movie is a stinker. The film is set on an Indian Reservation. Had it been set in the inner city or dying coal town it would be labeled pandering. The film poverty porn for upper-middle class white people to feel better about themselves. Everyone is poor and dealing drugs, or working on other shady side hustles. The idea being to really make sure you get how bad life is on the reservation (and the implication that white people are the cause of all the problems). There are a few nice shots, but not enough to keep the audience's attention. Most of the actors are not good enough to really deliver the lines. The end result is a slow two hours showing two characters stuck in poverty. [Well-reviewed Drama].
169. **The Palace:** Directed and co-written by Roman Polanski (*Rosemary's Baby*), the film is not very good (but no where near as bad as the reviews imply). Too many of the jokes fall flat, or have been done multiple times already (John Cleese doing a *Weekend at Bernie's* bit is the worst offender). There are simply too many characters that are jumbled with minimal development. It is a forced commentary about class, but at least the dialogue is never over-the-top with the commentary. Oliver Masucci as the hotel manager holds the film together and he is rather good in the film. The sets and costumes are only okay. It could have been better, and has a lot of flaws, but Polanski is still a great director (but horrible person). [Roman Polanski].
168. **Sound of Freedom:** The movie is not as bad as you'd expect. The cinematography is decent-to-good. The plot and dialogue are iffy. The acting mainly consists of staring at the camera and informing the audience the importance of saving children. For a thriller, it simply isn't thrilling enough. This is not awful film, but it also isn't good. The reason to avoid it has nothing to do with politics, but because the film is basic and not good. [I Had To And You Know Why], *Amazon Prime*.
167. **Dumb Money:** As an economist, I am not the audience for the film; I had a rough idea what happened with \$GME, and I am *relatively* more supportive of Hedge Funds than most people. The film doesn't explain enough details of the short squeeze; a good thriller could have been made focusing on the specific days short positions needed to be covered. The film also presents a far too simplistic view of the stock market (just put money in low-cost index funds! anything else is no different than gambling). The made-up characters who put money into \$GME do not work (did America Ferrera tell her agent she wanted to to play nothing but annoying and preachy characters in 2023?) were made to be overly sympathetic and the film avoided them losing money. There was also a good family drama about RoaringKitty's home life; Paul Dano and Shailene Woodley are capable actors. Instead it always reverts back to basic-level rich-people-bad tropes. [Talia Ryder], *Netflix*.
166. **Blue Beetle:** Dare I suggest the positive reviews were a result of critics not wanting to destroy the first Latino superhero movie? As the script itself is frequently bad (the screen writer's only other feature credit is a film with a 22% on RT, how did they find them?). The director Angel Manuel Soto

at least made *Charm City Kings* which was a enjoyable indie. The villain (played by a check-cashing Susan Sarandon) is a cartoon villain; the CEO of mega-corporation that makes missiles and also buys up homes?. The film literally starts with ‘Welcome to [DCEU’s Version of Miami], The Lowest Corporate Tax Rate in the World’ and you know exactly what kind of film it is going to be. It doesn’t help that in a few minutes we learn the family is losing their house (with no real explanation why; and yes gentrification is listed as a reason!), and then a joke from the younger sister about why she doesn’t want to go into debt for college. George Lopez is often funny, and the film does get a little better, albeit it stays predictable. Lastly, for a film that cost a little over 100 million, the VFX often look bad. What exactly did the budget go towards? The film was another massive miss as we hopefully reach the end of twenty years of superhero films. [Critic’s Choice Super Awards – Best Superhero Film Nominee], *HBOMax*.

165. **Here Out West:** *Crash*-for-the-Australian-immigrant-experience does not work for the same reason *Crash* does not work (well, minus everyone-is-a-bit-racist-but-they-mean-well); the film ends up being a collection of short films instead of a coherent feature. Characters get some development, but all of the development is crammed into twenty minutes. Each short is generally good, and should probably rank higher; there is a strong argument I am punishing too much for being a in-cohesive anthology. There are eight segments in 100 minutes. Meaning an average of 12 minutes for each. It does not work. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee].
164. **The Little Mermaid:** Anything underwater, or on water (that isn’t a simple seascape) often looks rough. *Avatar 2* set the standard, but this film does not even come close. Nothing looks remotely realistic if the scene is set below water. The film does make some small improvements to the original (such as why Ariel would fall in love with Eric; the Caribbean setting wasn’t actually used much beyond why the people were not white; sans Eric). On land some of the set and costumes are allowed to shine more. But the film itself is another in a long line of misses by Disney’s live action program. Halle Bailey is solid as Ariel, but none of the voice cast is special. Melissa McCarthy is particularly awful and nearly ruins the movie on her own. [Black Reel – Best Breakthrough Performance Nominee], *Disney+*.
163. **We Have a Ghost:** There a good family drama/comedy here, but film takes a few too many (crowd-pleasing?) detours. Jahi Winston (*Charm City Kings*) is very good as the the lonely child who befriends the ghost (played by a decent David Harbour). Add in an always good Anthony Mackie the film had a lot of potential. Sadly, it makes two plot errors that derail the entire film: the dad wants to turn the ghost records into viral videos and profit off them (the commentary on social media was lazy and masks the family drama), the government had a ghost-catching program which tries to hunt down the ghost (there is a pathetic car chase-sequence that nearly takes the viewer out of the film). What could have an been a funny and touching take on a broken family and coming-of-age film gets destroyed by pointless side plots that nearly become the entire plot. [Poorly-reviewed Horror], *Netflix*.

Tier 12: I Watch Too Many Horrors and Non-Horrors With One Salvage Quality

162. **Summoning Sylvia:** A horror-comedy that is neither scary nor funny. Also at 75 minutes, it was better off as a skit or short. The premise of a gay bachelor party at a haunted house worse as a premise, but only if scares and laughs can come from it, and they don’t. The commentary on gay culture is entry level; partially as none of the characters are developed (and all the gay characters are essentially the same stereotypical gay character). The twist – to the extent there even is one – is okay but doesn’t add much to the film. The film wants to be a campy delight, but not enough of the jokes land. [GLAAD – Best Limited Release Nominee].

161. **The Offering:** A horror film that brings little new to the genre, and if anything recycles a lot of familiar themes. The tension never really builds, until a conclusion that is too quick. The 90-minute runtime is poorly paced; the set up takes far too long with a quick conclusion. The scares are mainly easy/cheap jump scares. The set design is decent, but the drab colors is getting overused. There might be a few good things related to (Hasdic) Jewish culture that I missed (there is an easy comparison to *The Vigil* which was far spookier and developed its characters). The characters in this film are barely developed; a marriage might have troubles but nothing is ever alluded to, character's motivation is thru forced backstory. It also doesn't help that the film starts with a title card essentially outlining the plot, 'there exists in folklore a monster that takes children' [cut to pregnant lady]. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
160. **Sick:** There is a reason slasher films have stopped being made. There is little-to-nothing to add to the genre. This film attempts to add a Covid angle with little success; it comes across as forced social commentary. (There is an argument that we shouldn't be making Covid films because they frequently do not work, unless somehow Mark Duplass is involved.) The film itself isn't very scary, the characters – like most in slashers – have little development and serve as warm bodies that always make bad decisions. It manages to pack little into its 80 minute runtime. There are almost no scares. The one good thing is that the camerawork is often good. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Peacock*.
159. **Anyone But You:** There are exactly two good things about this film: Sydney Sweeney (*The Voyeurs*) and Glen Powell (*Top Gun: Maverick*, *Devotion*, *Set It Up*). Each is exactly the person you want as the lead in a rom-com; hot, charming, and funny. In scenes with only the two of them the film is enjoyable, because each of them is great. Yet when the script calls for scenes with supporting character, or even worse scenes of only supporting characters the film falls extremely flat. There is little substance to the film, and the plot itself is rather bad and filled with multiple contradictions. It is a shame the film wasted the talent of its leads. Yet it is an easy watch with two superstars as leads. [GLAAD – Best Wide Release Nominee], *Netflix*.
158. **Gran Turismo:** As a NASCAR fan I really wanted to like the film. One of the big developments in racing is time spent in the simulator (aka a high-end video game). NASCAR has seen iRacing stars make the transition to stock cars (with generous funding of course). The film does a good job at getting at the importance of simulation. And sadly that is where the good things end. The film is uninterested in the importance of car quality and the importance of consistency (win the race and you advance! this is not how you scout talent). Most characters are paper thin and so much effort is made to exist in the confines of a blockbuster; cartoon villains, a love interest, etc. Cars still go vroom and David Harbour is decent. [Black Reel Awards – Breakthrough Performance Nominee], *Netflix*.
157. **Shazam! Fury of the Gods:** The film is not exactly able to capture the magic of the first film. Zachary Levi is still enjoyable but not as funny as before. Adam Brody is always enjoyable, but again, it started wearing thin. The casting coup was getting Helen Mirren, Lucy Liu, and Rachel Zegler to play the villains (all of which are overqualified for the film; Zegler was at least honest and said she took the job for the money—respect). The effects are middling. Also set in Philly, does not have much of Philly-feel (if there was one city in America that I fully believe would kill mythical creatures attacking it, it would be Philly). The directing was rather meh, as multiple good parts could have been a lot better (feeding Skittles being a primary example). Yet, a few jokes still land, and it still heart-warming. [Sequel], *HBOMax*.
156. **Ruby Gillman, Teenage Kraken:** The film has possible the best voice cast: Toni Collette, Annie Murphy, Sam Richardson, Will Forte, Colman Domingo, and Jane Fonda! Though the comedic voices aren't given developed character and often times need to over-do their voice acting in an attempt to provide characterization. The large kraken look good, the are vibrant and bright (note: I did not said

detailed) and on a proper screen they do pop. The plot itself is too basic and predictable. Some of the water and hair do look good. Thankfully it a sweet 90 minutes. [Annie Outstanding Character Animation – Nominee], *Netflix*.

155. **Frybread Face and Me:** Another indie set on a reservation, and another dud on the list. Once again, an issue is finding acting talent, the actors are simply not good enough and that is only exacerbated by have two kids in the lead. It also leans more into Indian spirituality, in a way that I always find silly; imagine a movie about Catholics with them explaining how the Holy Trinity works (or any of the Catholic teachings)—it would be unnecessary in both cases. This film benefits from being a brisk 80 minutes; even if that includes some needless voice overs and ‘documentary’ flashback footage. There are still some decent character development for both child leads. [GLAAD – Outstanding Streaming Nominee], *Netflix*.
154. **Moving On:** Jane Fonda and Lily Tomlin are good but can not come close to saving the film. After the of a college friend, people reunite with their baggage and trauma. The trauma is heavy, but the backstory is often weak, and the jokes in the script aren’t funny enough (despite Lily Tomin’s solid delivery). Even at 82 minutes, it still feels long, as the characters are going thru the motions of overcoming their trauma and grief. Nothing happens organically, everything exists to forcibly advance the plot to its potentially deadly conclusion. (A cruel review would say the film was more interested in checking liberal social boxes than being a film). Malcolm McDowell is also enjoyable as the over-the-top ‘villain’. [GLAAD – Outstanding Wide Release Nominee], *Hulu*.
153. **Blaze:** Like many films in this tier, it has a good, but the execution is too lackluster (the overall rating is inflated by few critic reviews; those that are most likely to enjoy it review it, and/or because the subject matter is important when in doubt it is more socially acceptable to give a fresh rating—rant over). The primary issue with this film, it is the directorial debut of visual artist Del Kathryn Barton. They needed help with the script/dialogue and did not get enough. But the primary issue is there are non-stop fantasy sequences. The sequences do not work, and they are so frequent any time the viewer is about to get back into the film (again, there is a good coming-of-age film to be made here), another fantasy sequence starts. There are also far too many awkward POV shots. The film was not made by a film-maker. For a 100 minute minute movie, removing the fantasy sequences would cut the runtime to near 70 minutes I would guess. The inability to develop characters naturally hurts the film. Far too much characterization is outsourced to fantasy sequences. It does not work as a film. It is sad as both Simon Baker (*High Ground*) and Julia Savage are rather good, especially Savage. But both performances are drowned out by fantasy sequences. [AACTA – Best Actress Nominee].
152. **Our Son:** The film would be an exact replica of every 90s-divorce drama, except the lead couple is gay. From the parents; one works long hours an earns income for everyone, the other became a stay-at-home dad (who get’s bored and eventually cheats!); to dialogue that is overtly in the audience’s face about the character’s motivations (instead of having the fight be about a tiny thing that symbolizing the crumbling marriage, they simply fight over the crumbling marriage with every cliché line used). There is also a lot of therapy-speak used (and as a spoiler, even with a divorce everyone gets a happy ending!). Luke Evans does his best to save the film; he and Billy Porter are almost able to overcome its flaws but even they can not. Andrew Rannells (*The Prom*) is enjoyable in a supporting role as always. The film is a waste of everyone involved and re-treads everything viewers have seen before. [GLAAD – Outstanding Wide Release Nominee].
151. **Origin:** Co-written and Directed by Ava DuVernay (*Selma*), putting it nicely would call the film an ambitious miss. Aunjanue Ellis-Taylor (*If Beale Street Could Talk*) holds the film together as the there is a quality personal drama to be made; Niecy Nash (*Reno 911!*) and Jon Bernthal (*The Bear*) help make the personal drama work. But the film is farm more focused on being a quasi-documentary

of explaining the thesis of a book. It is ripe with voiceovers (I assume lifted from the book), writing ideas on a white board, and speeches explaining the thesis. The script is bad and leans into the quasi-documentary that one is lead to believe DuVernay didn't write it but rather an LLM trained on DEI statements. A literal line of dialogue is, 'I could build a thesis that shows how all of this is linked'. Even a surprise appearance by Nick Offerman is ruined by an on-the-nose MAGA hat. It devolves away from a narrative film to a lazy sociology lecture. [Black Reel Awards – Outstanding Film Nominee].

150. **Blueback:** A by-the-numbers film about environmental conservation. We see a mother's passion for the sea be instilled in her at-first 'cowardly' daughter. The daughter then finds her inner courage to meet boys, move away, and fight to save the ocean herself. The villains are of course greedy capitalists (but the film does a good job of not giving them many lines to avoid getting into completely cartoon territory). The shots of the ocean and the beaches often look rather nice, especially when clouds are rolling in. It is an easy and predictable watch. [AACTA – Best Supporting Actress Nominee], *Netflix*.
149. **Godless: The Eastfield Exorcism:** An attempt to subvert the exorcism film, by making the religious zealots the villains. Except the Jesus people come across as cartoon villains. Tim Pocock overdoes it as the exorcist brought in to 'heal' the wife. Georgia Evers is the best actor as the schizophrenic wife. The film does take too long to get to the character's backstories. As one starts to wonder why she'd ever marry a religious weirdo (or if he slowly became more religious over the course of their marriage). Near the end of the film there is finally a flashback which offers an explanation (and links to some of her schizophrenic visions), though sadly it comes too late. Had the film focused more on her experiences and tone-down the cartoon villain the subversion would have been more successful. The film was flooded with warm yellow light that did not do it for me either. [AACTA – Best Cinematography Nominee].
148. **The Pope's Exorcist:** The film is entirely held together by Russell Crowe being enjoyable and having fun as the titular exorcist. He tells jokes and brings a light-heartedness to a role that is normally deadly serious. The film attempts some ribbing of the Church as well. Except that everything set up in the first two-thirds, ends up going off the rails in the final third and nearly ruins the film. Instead of continuing to build characters the film goes for lazy 'shocks' and 'scares' when the flawed priests at the center of the film made it work (and Crowe). [Okay-reviewed Horror]
147. **Fair Play:** An erotic thriller that is only a little erotic, and not at all thrilling. At risk of "spoiling" anything, the film's plot is that the girlfriend gets a promotion and then in response the boyfriend instantly becomes a Jordan Peterson/Ben Shapiro (stand-in) follower. And that film progressively goes further off the rails. I assume some people will takeaway how hard it is being a woman in the workplace, but the film crafts that message so poorly the takeaway should be that the film is not worth watching; there are not characters but flimsy social stand-ins. Phoebe Dynevor is solid, and the costumes are rather good, along with the lighting. But the script from director Chloe Domont (her debut) ruins the entire film. [Well-reviewed Erotic Thriller], *Netflix*.
146. **Jules:** A quaint sci-fi film partially carried by its three leads. Ben Kingsley (*Ghandi*), Harriet Sansom Harris (*Fraiser*), and Jane Curtin (*being an ignorant slut*) are all rather good and give the film more drama and laughs than the script provides. The script starts with a shell of an idea; three elderly people encounter an alien and learn about loss, friendship, and acceptance along the way. Yet the script gives only the bare-bones of character development. There is enough to make it a nice feel-good film, but one you when you fly back to your home planet you wish your time with the film was more meaningful. [Well-reviewed Sci-fi].
145. **The Retirement Plan:** Nic Cage is Nic Cage and makes this film tolerable. He delivers his lines with great comedic inflection. Ron Pearlman is also solid in a supporting role. But the film itself is

often poorly shot (the ‘action’ scenes often look rather cheap/lazy). The film itself tries to be campy, but it rarely pulls it off (beyond the Cage moments). If you enjoy watching Nic Cage cook, it still can be worth watching, but otherwise it is largely forgettable. [Nic Cage], *Hulu*.

144. **Super Mario Bros:** The film is 90 minutes of fan service. And I am not a fan of the Mario franchise. I assume I missed hundreds of Easter (Yoshi?) Eggs in the film. Almost every transition or plot point is a (forced) reference to the franchise. The plot is paper thin and there is not much in the way of character development either. Most of the voice cast is a miss, producers seemed to want big names rather than people who would do a good job. Admittedly the animation often looks good; lots of details on Mario and Peach’s outfits. Yet with a budget of close to 100 million it makes sense a lot was spent on the animation. [PGA – Outstanding Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
143. **Operation Fortune: Ruse de Guerre** A Guy Ritchie action film so you know what you are getting; a fun time that you don’t need to think much about. The action sequences are rather weak. Instead the film is carried by Aubrey Plaza (*Black Bear*) and Hugh Grant as the primary villain. Hugh Grant appears three times on this list, and it needs to be stated that his career seems to be him accepting the over-the-top roles that aren’t right for Nic Cage; and this is an amazing development. Grant brings a special sauce of crazy to these roles and elevates his character and the film far more than they deserve. Jason Statham is okay in the lead role, and the ending implied there could be a sequel, but without Grant I doubt it will succeed as Dumb Fun Part 2 will need more than Aubrey Plaza’s charm to make it tolerable. [Fun Guy Ritchie].
142. **Knock at the Cabin:** In many ways, this ranking is too low. Dave Bautista (*Blade Runner 2049*) is really good and acts as the film’s center. He deftly guides the action and plot. It is a performance you wished one award zagged and nominated him. The premise, adapted from a novel, is very good. Yet the adaptation is filled with plot holes and dumb character decisions. M. Night Shyamalan (*Old*) continues his recent string of horrendous adaptations of quality source material. It is the poor adaptation that has the film rank here; it is probably better than here but we as a society need to do something and that something is stop watching his films (like a dolt, I’ll watch his next film). [Critic’s Choice Super Awards – Best Actor Horror Movie Nominee], *Peacock*.
141. **Indiana Jones and the Dial of Destiny:** I assume I missed a lot of easter eggs for fans of the franchise (I did get that eels are the snakes of the sea). There is a plot, but the 2:40 runtime is packed; it really does scream the serials Lucas adored as a kid (Lucas had minimal involvement). Every fifteen minutes is a new fight or chase in a new location. Harrison Ford is still as good as ever, and Phoebe Waller-Bridge (*Fleabag*) is a personal favorite, even if her character is hardly developed. The final thirty minutes does go off the rails, and continues the absurdity in *Crystal Skull*. Though I assume fans of the franchise enjoyed it, which is kinda the problem here. [Oscars – Best Score], *Disney+*.
140. **The Artifice Girl:** This film almost certainly ranks higher than where I have it. Except, I will rank it this low as it explains far too much about how Artificial Intelligence works. The film is about 90 minutes (a three-act play essentially) and too much of the dialogue is detailing AI and the ethics surrounding it. The film is made for people who have not spent much time thinking about AI; if you are very familiar with AI the arguments made would be old hat. Also that the film is focused on child pornography, it seems the topic was picked to be relevant to ‘current’ social issues. The cast isn’t very good; Sinda Nichols overdoes it at times. However it is a good showcase on how to make a film on almost zero budget, and others might get a lot more out of it. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award Nominee].
139. **Raging Grace:** The film is marketed as a horror, but it is not scary (perhaps if it was not marketed as a horror it would rank a little higher? but there are still a lot of flaws). It was the film debut of co-writer and director of Paris Zarcilla, who does not give us a reason to be interested in his next film.

The writing is rather poor, as in an attempt to portray the immigrant lifestyle it turns the wealthy Brits into cartoon villains (complete with overacting). The immigrant experience is a crowded genre (even the immigrant experience horror has a few entries!) and this does not make any new in-roads. There is a speech that is too heavy-handed. The film is a major miss. [British Independent Film – Break Through Producer Nominee], *Paramount+*.

138. **The Unknown Country:** By most standards this film should rank much higher: Lily Gladstone is good, the film slowly reveals characterization by showing – not telling. The first problem with the film is that it is a quasi-documentary ala *Nomadland* (which I was critical of for many of the same reasons repeated here). The non-actors are not very good (sans the kid). For a film that runs 85 minutes much of the runtime is padded with (admittedly gorgeous) American snowscapes and voice overs (of the non-actors’ life stories; which makes the film feel aimless—is it about Gladstone’s character or the people she meets along the way?), I don’t think I’ve seen such a short film where nothing happens. Even as an American road-trip film, it doesn’t work as the ‘length’ of time it takes Gladstone to drive places is incoherently long. Distances that are perhaps eight hours, appear to take at least a day-and-a-half, complete with late-night stops at gas stations; sometimes she is on the highway and other times she is back county roads. There is no cohesion to this film. It is a miss and a waste of Gladstone’s talent. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award Nominee].
137. **Joy Ride:** A rauchy sex comedy reminiscent of *The Hangover* and *Bridesmaids* and *Girl’s Trip* that lacks the humor, innovation, and talent of its predecessors. However the all-woman Asian angle, is not enough to justify a film. Ashley Park (*Emily in Paris*) is decent in the lead, but not great (and astute viewers will predict the plot twist). Sherry Cola is good as the best friend. Stephanie Hsu (*Everything Everywhere All at once*) is the best and continues to show that her breakthrough in *EEAAO* was well-deserved. There are a great handful of guest appearances from Baron Davis to Daniel Dae Kim. Yet too many of the jokes fail to land, and the zany plot does not make too much sense (it gets too episodic and unlike the great screwball comedies that naturally flow from one event to the other the transitions seem forced). It leans into cultural issues too much (the boss calling himself an ally). Ronny Chieng (*Vacation Friends 2*) continues to be funny in a supporting role. But this movie was made a few years too late to add much to the genre. [Well-reviewed Comedy].
136. **Plane:** A semi-generic action movie with Gerard Butler able to slightly elevate it. None of the sequences stand out as extraordinary, but there are multiple solid action sequences. It does have many plot holes (besides some dumb behavior of the person escorting a prisoner; the film needed to have him killed but could have done so in a better way; also a character drinks a Sip of Sunshine on a flight from Singapore to Tokyo but that goof is for the beer nerds—the goofs on IMDb are all plane-related). It is a tight film that hearkens back to the dad movies of the 90s. [Well-reviewed Action].
135. **Extraction 2:** I have copied-and-pasted my review from the initial *Extraction* film and made some updates, as they are essentially the same film. Most of the film is a standard action movie; reused themes, video game-like endless stream of ‘villains’/bodies to shoot. Yet there is one sequence that is amazing (depending on the weight one places on that one sequence the film could easily move up, or down, a tier). The lengthy jail-break sequence is amazing and is honestly one of the best of year (the initial film had a 12-minute sequence whereas here it is upped to 21 minutes). Sadly it occurs in the beginning of the film and therefore everything feels like a let down afterwards (especially when they need to shift gears into attempting character development). It also doesn’t help that most of the post-jail break plot is non-nonsensical—especially considering the (lack of) risk evaluation an elite team of extractors uses. At the end of the day, this is another – in a growing list – of *John Wick* knock offs. But as long as there is a epic sequence I will still watch. [Critic’s Choice Super Awards – Best Action Movie Nominee], *Netflix*.

134. **A Stitch in Time:** A feel-good film that at least is feel-good. The script is predictable, the dialogue is bland and often pure exposition, and most of the acting is flat. The film was written and directed by debut filmmaker Sasha Hadden, perhaps if the cast was improved with quality actors there would be enough charm to overcome the many flaws. [AACTA – Best Independent Film Winner].
133. **Runs in the Family:** The film could rank a tier (or two) higher if the last act did not fall apart. Far too much happens in the last fifteen minutes, and although most of it was hinted at in the film it muddles the plot. The film is at its best as a father-and-son LGBT film, the moments that introduce the mother initially allow for a plot but eventually clouds the film. Reworking the ending would greatly improve the film. A knock is that there are a few too many speeches about gender that are aimed at people who are not the audience for the film. But the father played by Ace Bhatti is good and Gabe Gabriel (also the son of the director) is good. [GLAAD – Outstanding Streaming Film Nominee], *Netflix*.

Tier 11: Tolerable Romances and Horrors (and Others)

132. **Chicken Run: Dawn of the Nugget:** The film is enjoyable enough but lacks the full charm of the first film. Partially because the first was a crisp 80 minutes, whereas this film is (a still enjoyable) 100 minutes. For practical purposes there are not many new characters introduced. Some of the voice cast was replaced, also for the worse (thankfully Jane Horrocks returned as she voices the best jokes). The sets look extremely good and detailed; one benefit of the stop-motion films is that the sets are real. The plot itself is a little contrived as the mother tells her daughter that humans will try and kill you; instead only saying leaving the island is a hard no. It is enjoyable family fun with enough solid animation for the adults. [BAFTA – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
131. **Somebody I Use to Know:** Dave Franco's (*The Rental*) second film, co-written with his wife and the lead Alison Brie, it establishes them as a combo that makes decent films. This one is nothing to write home about. It does have something new to say about the rom-com genre, yet the initial premise is that of a Hallmark movie; an career-focused woman returns to her home town after work troubles and rekindles an old flame (some people might be out in the first fifteen minutes). And by time the newer themes comes thru the film is nearly over (and then is rushed at that). All while both female leads (Brie and Kiersey Clemons) are not exactly fully developed. Less time with the supporting characters of Danny Pudi (*DuckTales*) and Haley Joel Osment could have allowed for more development of the main characters. Some of the jokes are funny, but often feel forced, rather than occurring organically during plot development. [Alison Brie], *Amazon Prime*.
130. **The Other Zoey:** A mediocre rom-com that spends most of its time deriding the standard issues with rom-coms, and then proceeds to have characters do all of of them. Perhaps if you believe the meta-humor lands it can rank better for you, but for the most part it falls flat. The plot and character decisions are pointless. The college-aged leads are attractive, but that is about all they bring to the table. Like most of these rom-coms, it is the adult actors that are far better: Patrick Fabian (*Better Call Saul*), Heather Graham (*Boogie Nights*), and Andie MacDowell (*Sex, Lies, and Videotape*). One almost wishes the rom-com was a love triangle between those three. Olive Abercrombie (*The Haunting of Hill House*) gets to crush the younger sister role, though with kids it is hard to judge, but could be worth watching. If you are in the mood for an easy-watch and predictable-but-fun rom-com it worth watching. [Well-reviewed Rom-Com], *Amazon Prime*.
129. **Aristotle and Dante Discover the Secrets of the Universe:** The fundamental issue of the film is that as an adaptation of a novel, it does not exactly work. I assume the novel has passages of the letters the title characters wrote each other, but in the film the voice-overs do not work as much. The alleged chemistry between them isn't there to carry a film. The time spent developing them as characters is also rather weak, with some basic and predictable plots points. The YA-LGBT genre is

growing and this film does not have enough to add to it; the Mexican-American angle isn't exactly built up beyond some mild cliches. The views on masculinity have been done before in other films. Perhaps if made in 2012 when the novel came out it would be much better, but 12 years later most of it has been already. [GLAAD – Best Limited Release Nominee].

128. **Red, White, & Royal Blue:** A mediocre LGBT film that often feels like a fanfic turned into a film. Uma Thurman has a supporting role and is a career worse; how no one stopped her Texas accent is baffling. The stars of the film are the two leads: Taylor Zakhar Perez and Nicholas Galitzine are both attractive and charming enough. The script flips between helping them and hurting them. There are some witty jokes, but a few lulls, and a few LGBT-rights speeches. The supporting cast (ignoring Thurman) is good, especially Sarah Shahi. A tight script, replacing Uma Thurman, and cutting about fifteen minutes would have greatly improved the film. [PGA – Best Streaming Film Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
127. **The New Boy:** The film has a lot to say about (the crushing conformity of organized) Christianity vs indigenous faith, but can never piece it all together. Writer-director Warwick Thornton aimed for too much and did not have the skill to pull it off. Although the Austrian wilderness shots are gorgeous and multiple shots are expertly framed (Thornton also did his own cinematography, so he deserves some praise for that); these shots inflate the runtime to almost two hours (when the film had closer to an hour-forty of content). It also does not help that the shots often lack scoring, resulting in an even larger bore. Cate Blanchett is decent as the nun, but the script is too weak to give her a lot to work with. Newcomer Aswan Reid is rather good as the new boy at the orphanage. But the flaws are simply too much to overcome. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee].
126. **True Spirit:** The film is an extremely-standard feel-good inspirational film for girls and women. Luckily there is hardly ever an instance where you'll facepalm. The cast is decent, even if there is little character development; Cliff Curtis is probably the best but again that might be a function of his character having the most development. Perhaps a few scenes could be cut to get the film down to 100 minutes instead of 110; even though it doesn't drag. Rather it simply doesn't have much to say as the story has been before. [AACTA – Best Production Design Nominee], *Netflix*.
125. **The Angry Black Girl and Her Monster:** The primary issue is that the film does not know who it is for. Early scenes hammer home race issues in way that is already outdated; "where are you from?" "that name is too hard to pronounce, I'll call you..." among a few others. These put the viewer off as rather than be a film about family relationships, loss (and race). Instead it instantly is a poor film about race. It does eventually get back to being a decent family, but it is hard to stay focused. It also doesn't help that the film wants to be a horror, but is rarely scary. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
124. **Merry Little Batman:** A fun little family Christmas movie. It hits familiar notes (it is partially for kids after all), but it has enough for adults and an actual plot; even if the plot is a little too explained (it is partially for kids after all). The best part is the character design; Joker and Alfred look interesting; it is nice to see the film take fun stylistic choices. The animation, as in the movement of characters, itself isn't the best but this isn't exactly a big budget film; focus in on the designs and backgrounds. [Annie Awards – Best Character Design Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
123. **Carmen:** A loose modernization of the opera of the same name (which I have never seen). The film was shot in 2021, so although it stars Paul Mescal (*Aftersun*) it was before he broke out in 2022. And it shows; the director rarely trusted Mescal to carry scenes. The camera would rarely linger on his face, he would be in the background and out of focus, or the film would cut to a fantasy/dream-type sequence. Mescal does show flashes of brilliance (a phone booth scene being the prime example), but is not allowed to shine. The exact same can be said about Melissa Barrera (*In the Heights*). Benjamin Millepied (*fumbling the bag of being married to Natalie Portman*) was a first-time film

director and did not allow his actors to shine. He is primarily a choreographer and some of the dance sequences do look good (not the ones involving Paul Mescal; dancing is one thing Mescal can't do). The main issue with the dance sequences, is that they rarely tonally fit with the rest of the film. They detract from the drama, despite looking good. There was a good film to be made here, but this was not it. [Paul Mescal].

122. **The Persian Version:** One's enjoyment of the film will be how much they buy into the voice overs and the plot (meta) structure. If the voice overs are a major turn off, the film will rank about here, if you buy-in, it can rank a tier or two higher. The plot is also wildly divergent; at times it wants to be a bonkers comedy, at other times a serious drama. It can not mesh its various themes and tones the way it wants. The film also suffers in the same way most autobiographical (pet project) films do; it refuses to skim the real-life fat. Although there are lots of brothers, the film did not require that many. All of the religious 'miracles' are not needed. There is a good mother-daughter film here, but the execution was too poor. [National Board of Review – Top 10 Independent Film], *Netflix*.
121. **Quiz Lady:** A film that is consistently let down by its writing. Multiple jokes do not land; despite the effort Akwafina and Sandra Oh give in delivering them (Tony Hale is really the only one able to get consistent comedy out of his lines). The plot itself is far too fanciful with almost nothing grounded in reality (if you can get over the plot perhaps it will be more entertaining to you). Will Ferrell is a delight playing a version of Alex Trebek (that is not Trebek and the quiz show is not Jeopardy). Not being Jeopardy but obvious-about-Jeopardy, even more of the plot points fell short; Jason Schwartzman character is a caricature and a bad one at that (most Jeopardy contestants are beloved). [Critic's Choice – Best TV Movie Winner], *Hulu*.
120. **Love at First Sight:** One's enjoyment of the film will almost certainly come down to their buy-in on the plot gimmick; Jameela Jamil (*The Good Place*) narrates while playing an omnipresent guide to help them fall in love. Though given I am an Economist, and Ben Hardy (*The Voyeurs*) plays a statistics grad student who behaves like a person-who-knows-nothing-about-statistics-thinks-a-person-who-knows-statistics-behaves is too irksome. As expected with a rom-com the plot is predictable, but it does at least try to develop some relationships. Yet even Haley Lu Richardson (*Columbus*) can not carry this film. [Well-reviewed Rom Com], *Netflix*.
119. **A Haunting in Venice:** The third Kenneth Branagh adaptation of Hercule Poirot. As has become standard, the sets and costumes are rather good (here the sets are far darker and gloomier). The cast is not as strong as previous films but Michelle Yeoh and Jamie Dornan are both good. Tina Fey is not that good. Instead, the film makes great use of lesser known actors: Jude Hill (working again with Branagh after starring in *Belfast*), Emma Laird, and Amir El-Masry (*Limbo*, 2020). The mystery is probably the weakest of the three films. Though the main reason for not ranking another tier higher is the film wants to have its cake and eat it too when it comes to the supernatural. It comes across as pandering to a certain type of audience member—a type who does not need pandering. [Poirot Franchise], *Hulu*.
118. **Slotherhouse:** A movie about a killer sloth who reeks havoc on a social-media obsessed sorority? It is as dumb and fun as it sounds. It can't keep up the fun, as it loses its luster after about 35 minutes. Luckily, there are enough fun moments left in the film, that it never becomes awful or too boring. None of the actresses are impressive, except maybe for Olivia Rouyre and Bianca Beckles-Rose. The film's social commentary is thin, and narrow (compared to say *M3gan* which had an equally silly premise, but actual characters). Perhaps the best bit of the movie is ruined by the title, a character says, 'don't go in there, it's a slotherhouse', which is extremely dumb and groan-worthy. But if one did not know the title, it would be a peak dad joke. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
117. **The Blackening:** A horror-comedy that is lacking in both horror and comedy. The dialogue was allegedly largely improvised, which almost certainly contributed to the lack of laughs. And the

worst part is the film had an interest premise; a group of (black) friends meeting up for a weekend and are forced to play a racist game to survive. There is some social commentary, but in a post-*Get Out* world, it needs to be a lot stronger (especially when taking the ‘easier’ route of being a horror-comedy). The cast was solid (again, had they been given a script with funny dialogue this could easily rank higher); X Mayo (*American Auto*) being my favorite. [Black Reel – Outstanding Ensemble Nominee].

116. **Thanksgiving:** A horror-comedy that is light on the horror, and is over-reliant on innovated/absurd kills to keep the plot going (there are multiple good ones; and if you get into them it could easily move the film up a tier). The film tries too hard to keep the audience guessing who the killer will be and that ends up being a distraction (is it the ex-boyfriend who re-appeared before the murders started? the new boyfriend who was a social outcast? someone else?). It also does not help that none of the teens really stand out. The adults are a shockingly good list of actors: Patrick Demsey, Rick Hoffman (*Suits*), and Gina Gershon (*Rifkin’s Festival*). It a fun-enough B-movie. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Netflix*.
115. **Where the Devil Roams:** Another micro-budget horror from the Adams family. This film is more body horror and never really comes together. The film leaves multiple plot points unspoken, but there isn’t enough meat in the characters to keep the film moving forward. It tries to juggle a few too many themes and they do not all come together. The visuals are still great and one of the family’s hallmarks. Zelda Adams is still a great actress and will hopefully get a breakout into mainstream films (or she can keep making interesting micro-budget horrors). The family makes decent films, but some reviews might be overly generous as you need to laud them for doing so much (including the score) with so few resources. [Well-reviewed Horror]
114. **You Hurt My Feelings:** Written and directed by Nicole Holofcener (*Enough Said*), it is a fun-enough comedy. It tries to get a little too much out of the premise that couples tell each other white lies. There are enough jokes to keep the film, but not enough to have it excel. It helps that Julia Louis-Dreyfus is the lead with Michaela Watkins as her sister. The bits of therapy pad the already-brief runtime and although they allow for some solid guest appearances it doesn’t add much to the plot. There isn’t exactly anything wrong with the film and it is an enjoyable way to kill 90 minutes. [Well-reviewed Comedy], *Paramount+*.

Tier 10: Good Premises That Didn’t Fully Deliver

113. **The Lesson:** A thriller that isn’t very thrilling. The film does not build up enough suspense or mystery surrounding the wealthy family (and with the structure of the film, it does think it think it is achieving those goals). Even with a plot that needs improving, the film can stand on its own because the cast is simply too good; Daryl McCormack (*Good Luck to You, Leo Grande*), Richard E Grant (*Everybody’s Talking About Jamie*), and Julie Deply (*Before* trilogy). Each of them is able give the characters more depth than the script does, and their subtle mannerisms keep the film afloat; Grant’s ‘writing’ and Deply’s stares being the best of the bunch. [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Paramount+*.
112. **The Boys in the Boat:** A technically well-made film, with a few excellent shots and a lovely score from Alexandre Desplate. Yet the film is let down by a poor script, and worst of all, a script that makes you wonder what actually happened; the biggest offenders being the last-minute raising of funds, the last-minute lane change, and the ‘photo’ finish (in real life it was close but not a photo finish). I also have doubt that people were crowded around their radios to listen to coverage of a semi-obscure Olympic final. Joel Edgerton is good as always, Hadley Robinson (*Anyone But You*) is good but is given a character that is simply ‘devoted girlfriend’ (the lack of actual character development

hurts). The inspiration still often lands, but the story itself prefers to be one told since the Great Depression. [George Clooney].

111. **The Equalizer 3:** Much like the looming review of *John Wick: Chapter 4*, this series has also started to run its course. Denzel Washington is good as always. The film does have a few awesome fight sequences. Yet after a suspenseful start, there is a major lull as McCall ingrains himself with the local Italian community. Then, big shocker, he decides to help the community fight back against their oppressors. But it takes too much time for that decision to be made as there is little character development during those thirty minutes and the audience knows the end result. Introducing Dakota Fanning's character was a nice touch and gives the franchise an easy way of continuing if it wants (though the second film ended on a better send off). [Critic's Choice Super Awards – Best Actor in Action Movie Nominee], *Netflix*.
110. **Medusa Deluxe:** The film starts with a gorgeous one-shot take. The viewer is drawn into the mystery. But the film becomes a one-shot, and the beauty of the cinematography and editing start to fade. Part of the reason the one-shot fails is there are too many characters; since the film can't cut to them or inter-cut various concurrent conversations it takes a long time to introduce all of the characters in the who-dun-it and by then the viewer has lost interest (far too much of the film is characters walking down hallways to allow the camera to reach its next destination 'seemlessly'). The script itself contains some good parts and a few nice callbacks, but the one-shot make the film too slow. The dialogue nor the cast is strong enough to carry the action as the camera lingers. Yet for all its flaws, I am interested in what writer-director Thomas Hardiman does next as the one-shot filming is audacious enough to earn my respect; even if the execution was off. [British Independent Film – Best Production Design Nominee].
109. **Lonely Castle in the Mirror:** A decent anime about bullying (and loss?; the themes get muddled at the prolonged ending) that is not as good as *Silent Voice* which covered much of the same topics but better a few years back. The animation itself is mostly fine, with some of the computer animated parts looking a tad iffy. The climax is moving enough and helps to elevate the film. However the mystery of the castle is never mysterious enough (the view can quickly guess the characters connection) and the puzzle the kids must solve is explained in a straight-forward and nonsensical manner. It might be too off-putting some views and rank it far lower, it is a bad deus ex machina (again the climax is moving enough to make up for the flaws). The film goes further and explains everything to the audience, well after an astute viewer would have figured everything out by paying attention to the background pieces. [Japanese Animation Prize – Nominee].
108. **How to Blow Up a Pipeline:** When a film is overtly political and stupid and conservative it gets rated accordingly. Yet, an eco-terrorist liberal film got far too high of ratings. The ragtag group of eco-terrorists (don't worry they even have a discussion if they are terrorists) makes some sense: with idiotic climate doomers being the first introduced (this review could be how the climate is not doomed and that we are making excellent progress). As perhaps the biggest issue is the characters are only portrayed as sympathetic. There is no interest in criticizing the movement (would these people also block solar farms? one character joins the gang because eminent domain was used for a pipeline; what about a solar farm?). Now the film manages to keep up most of the thrill with solid suspense, and most people would ignore the political message and rank the film up a tier or two. Yet it is about a group of people that should be mocked and therefore the review needs to be mocking. [Independent Spirit – Best Editing Winner], *Hulu*.
107. **Dungeons & Dragons: Honor Among Thieves:** Now this is how you do fan service while still making a serviceable movie. There is little one needs to know about DnD before watching, and most of the semi-subtle fan service makes plot sense; the references are not forced but often occur organically. Chris Pine is rather good, but his charm is not enough to fully carry the film and at times

it gets borderline tiresome. There is enough backstory to each character. Hugh Grant (*Paddington 2*) is once again a delight as smarmy backstabber (I might need a a Nic Cage-esque gonzo film of Hugh Grant playing multiple villains all trying to back stab each other). The plot becomes a little too predictable, and at times the effects are iffy. It doesn't have enough jokes or the special sauce to get into the next tier. [Critic's Choice Super Awards - Best Actor in Science Fiction Movie Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

106. **Scrapper:** A heart-warming comedy about loss and family. The direction takes a few too many gambles that do not pay off (a few times the film takes a 'documentary' approach where other characters speak directly to the camera as if they are being interviewed about the lead character; yet if those were cut the 85-minute runtime would be closer to 75 minutes. There are other tonally-awkward bits). Newcomer Lola Campbell is decent as the kid. One's enjoyment will almost entirely depend on how heart-warming they find the film. [British Independent Film – Best Director Nominee], *Paramount+*.
105. **Totally Killer:** A film that had a unique sci-fi/horror/comedy premise: time-traveling back to the 80s to stop a string of slasher murders. Yet the film makes the same bad joke about the 80s being different (smoking, drinking and driving, sexism, bullying, school security, etc). By the time you've heard the joke for the second time it has worn out its welcome. And sadly for the audience, you'll hear it another ten times. The film also doesn't fully embrace being set in the late-80s, which doesn't help it either. Kiernan Shipka (*The Blackcoat's Daughter*) is decent as the lead, but not good enough to carry the film (the same can be said about Olivia Holt's role as well). It is difficult to come away not thinking this could have been funnier, more focused with it's critique of the 80s and satire of slasher films, while being a tad more scary (it comes off as a less-good *Freaky*). [WGA – Best Streaming Film Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
104. **Jethica:** The film has an interesting premise, and a brief 70-minute runtime. One wishes it used its runtime better, and was also a little longer. Too much of the runtime is spent on Kevin's rants. One was enough, the second and third are not needed. Callie Hernandez (*Under the Silver Lake*) is good, and her opening one-take speech that sets the stage for the film is rather good. She is able to capture the viewers attention. One wishes they did more with her character and that of Jessica's together. The film does end up having interesting things to say about (male) loneliness, but better developing the female leads would have made for a much better film. [Well-reviewed Thriller].
103. **Aporia:** Written and directed by Jared Moshe, by time the film finds its most interesting dramatic concept, it is nearly over. The film relies too much on explaining ethics; perhaps people who do not sit around thinking about the Trolley Problem most days will find it more interesting; a 'time-machine' of sorts is built that allows someone in the past to be killed. The film spends too much time on the ethics of using the machine than exploring the dramatic affects. Judy Greer (*Arrested Development*) is good as the lead, but given the weakness of the plot, is not able to carry the film (Greer is an underrated actress but also not an elite one). Eventually the film creates an interesting butterfly effect situation, but explains away the drama in a brief speech. The ending is left mildly-ambiguous in what is a giant cop-out. The film is science-fiction, decide how you want it to end because it is made up. [Well-reviewed Science Fiction], *Hulu*.
102. **Landscape with Invisible Hand:** The film had an amazing premise and one you'll want to love, but sadly wont be able to. The film starts with aliens contacting Earth and 'giving' Earth their amazing technology but in turn disrupting society and exacerbating inequality. Also these aliens are asexuals and can not feel love. Yet after twenty minutes of that idea, it shifts gears to another driving plot force (admittedly, the change in plot is natural, logical, and well-incorporated). But in changing the driving force, the film casts an even wider net on ideas it wants to touch on. And every twenty minutes the cycle repeats, resulting in such a wide net that little is actually caught. Tiffany

Haddish (*The Card Counter*) is great as always. While the rest of the cast is decent but not worth mentioning. [Well-reviewed Science Fiction], *Amazon Prime*.

101. **Skinamarink:** The low-budget horror has been compared to *The Blair Witch Project*, yet *Blair Witch* was a tight 81 minutes, and this film is a little over 100 minutes. That twenty minute difference is the difference between this film ranking a lot higher. There are some good scary moments, but they get forgotten as the film frequently drags. The other main sin, is that the film is set in 1995, but shot digitally, so a horrendous grainy filter seems to be applied to give it the 'look' of 1995 (but it isn't exactly a found footage, so there was no reason to do this!). Shots look extra blurry (admittedly the film was made with minimal lighting). The film could have been special as it is unique and experimental. Yet too many poor directing decisions ruined the potential. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
100. **Sweet As:** A standard coming-of-age troubled-youth film. A rag-tag group of kids is taken on a photography trip, for various reasons but all have their own demons and issues. However those demons and issues are never fully explored. They are hinted at, but the characters could have been much deeper. Then of course they eventually come together and start to overcome their issues, but even that feels rushed. The beautiful Australian Outback looks amazing and the film is well-shot. There was an interesting premise, but never did enough. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee]
99. **The Portable Door:** An enjoyable adventure/sci-fi films that seems aimed at young adults, but never stoops to that level. It is also clear there is an attempt at creating a franchise (it is based on a book series), and a few more might be worthwhile; the sets are nice and it isn't overly reliant on special effects and spectacle. It helps that Christoph Waltz and Sam Neill (*Rams*) are the adults, while both of the early-twenties leads are decent as well. The commentary on social media terms and conditions is too on-the-nose, but again given the target audience it is better than expected. [AACTA – Best Production Design Nominee].
98. **Shortcomings:** Randall Park's directorial debut, and he might want to stick to acting (as he is hilarious and charming). The film is a start vehicle for Justin H. Min (*After Yang*, *The Umbrella Academy*, and *Beef*). He is rather good in the film, and carries it through most every lull. He also gives the character the balance needed to frequently agree with him, but while realizing he is wrong frequently enough to be the problem in the relationships. The film itself is set up in brief section (each with title card) and it hurts the flow, the vignettes do not exactly fit together and results in the film dragging at the end. Far too much emphasis is place on inter-racial dating (specifically Asians and Whites; and if there is a meaningful difference if the genders are swapped in the relationship). Not all of the jokes land either. [GLAAD – Best Wide Release Nominee], *Netflix*.
97. **The Covenant:** Written and directed by Guy Ritchie (*The Gentlemen*), the film eases up on a lot of potential Guy Ritchie-ism as the film stays grounded in reality. There are multiple fire fights and a few explosions, but almost all look and feel realistic (the sound could have been a little better, but it was still good). This was not an over-the-top action film but a well-made (the landscape shots are really good). It still has few flourishes (a few names and phrases get written out) but nothing antagonizing. Jake Gyllenhaal is okay, but his character is semi-basic; an interpreter saved his life, so he feels the need to repay the favor. It is a decent film, and great reminder that the United States failed thousands of Afghan interpreters. Thousands of Afghan families should be living here in the US right now, but are not. [Well-reviewed Action], *Amazon Prime*.
96. **No Hard Feelings:** A raunchy sex-comedy that simply isn't that funny; there are some laughs but not enough. The plot is rather basic and predictable. Jennifer Lawrence does her best and really adds to the film. The generational differences between Millennials and Gen Z does not exactly work, as it wanted to simultaneously make fun of Gen Z while saying Millenials are old. The commentary on the Long Island housing market is rather bad (the issue is not rich people buying up homes from locals,

but the refusal to build new housing). Natalie Morales (*Language Lessons*) is good as a supporting character, but it is not given enough screen-time or development to really shine. Re-read the last sentence but replace Natalie with Ebon Moss-Bachrach (*The Bear*). [Critic's Choice – Best Comedy Nominee], *Netflix*.

95. **Creed III:** The primary issue with the film, is that it is two films pressed into one; Creed's childhood friend getting out of prison only to land a title fight, and then Apollo's return to the ring. Each of those should have been their own film; though with Jonathan Majors being a piece of shit in real-life, that probably couldn't happen. As a result, few characters are developed (especially Major's character in the lead up to the Creed fight); it is nice the franchise finally distanced itself from the character of Rocky. Michael B Jordan also directs in his debut and does a solid job. Some of VFX look iffy, and at times the fight sequences are a tad too stylized. However for the most part the film does look good. [Black Reel – Best Director Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
94. **Rye Lane:** A tolerable rom-com that avoids a lot of the genre pitfalls, and cringy crowd-pleasing moments. There are some laughs, but not nearly enough. The leads are good, but nothing special. (The lower ranked rom-coms on this list at least had funny attractive people hanging out; this features semi-funny people hanging out). The idea of a walk-and-talk rom-com ala *Before* franchise works, but the leads do not have the charisma to carry the film. The frequent fish-eye cinematography becomes grating. And at risk of going full old man, the film often feels aimed at a younger generation, 'I declined the interview [for my dream job] because I've already been rejected *four* times.' Even the required falling out two-thirds thru is a result of insecurity. There is a lovely Colin Firth cameo, which helps (and I guess he does count as a funny-and-attractive character). [BAFTA – Best Actress Nominee], *Hulu*.
93. **If You Were Last:** The film probably deserves to be in the next tier, but it is extremely similar to *Biosphere*; both feature two people 'stuck' together with a sci-fi twist and focus on their relationship. *If You Were Last* is the less serious of the two, though its quirks are fun. The set design is rather good and makes the drifting space shuttle a cozy home (even if defies a logic on how space shuttles are set up). Anthony Mackie (*Synchronic*) is good, so is Zoe Chao, but one wishes she was replaced with someone better. For example Natalie Morales (*Language Lessons*) is in the film and a stronger lead. The film can't exactly bring home the final third. It is quirky enough with enough laughs and emotion. Perfect for a feel-good watch. [Well-reviewed Sci-fi], *Peacock*.
92. **The Sweet East:** The film is far too episodic to excel, with most of the episodes being comments on current American culture (I did enjoy that the episodes are marked by silent-filmeqsue title cards). The quality of the episodes is almost always a function of the quality of the co-star. The Nazi sequence is the best because Simon Rex (*Red Rocket*) is great and one of the few actors able to match Talia Ryder (*Never, Rarely, Sometimes, Always* and *Do Revenge*). Make no mistake, this is Ryder's film and she single-handedly carries it. She is an amazing young actor and needs the chance to carry more films. Somehow the film manages to waste Ayo Edebiri who wasn't given the chance to shine in her role. It was the first film cinematographer-turned-director Sean Price Williams, who has photographed multiple low-budget independent films. The film far often has his low-budget and grainy style that is often off-putting. The best review of the film will always be, 'The Sweet East is basically a documentary about what a Pretty Girl can get away with' from a Twitter user. It is a shame the film was not as good as Ryder performance. [Talia Ryder], *Hulu*.
91. **Influencer:** The film is more of a thriller than the horror it was advertised as, but this is not a problem. As the title implies, the film is a criticism of influencer culture. A fair bit of the criticism is basic (but almost never in your face so it works), though towards the end the film gets a few more quality jabs in. The plot itself is a bit predictable (of course the boyfriend that bailed on the trip eventually comes looking for her!), but for the most part the basic plot is forgiven as Cassandra Naud

is rather good as the influencer serial killer; her ability to get ‘into character’ to gain the various influencer’s trust is really good. She nearly carries the film on her own. Kurtis David Harder’s direction is crisp with some nicely framed shots and keeps the tension high. [Well-reviewed Horror].

90. **Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: Mutant Mayhem:** The animation style is unique and often looks rather good. Sadly it seems the film will frequently be overlooked for animation awards as the film is neither a masterpiece, and indie delight, nor a money printer. The turtles are voiced by actual teenagers which helps lend a bit of authenticity (and the focus of the turtles being teenagers who want to be normal kids), but they have a hard time keeping up with an all-time voice cast (Seth Rogen, John Cena, Rose Byrne, Giancarlo Esposito, Paul Rudd, Hannibal Buress, Ice Cube, and Jackie Chan). The screenplay is decent with enough plot, even if it obviously is trying to jump-start the franchise. Perhaps the worst part is the extremely modern pop culture references, some of which are dated (and dare I say cringe) by time I watched it. [Annie Awards – Best Film Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

Tier 9: Ryan is Afraid to Rank this Film

89. **Beau is Afraid:** Ari Aster’s (*Hereditary* and *Midsommar*) overly long mental health prestige gambit is the most difficult film of the year to rank, and therefore it gets its own tier. The visuals are great as always with Pawel Pogorzelski once again doing cinematography for Aster. One has to wonder if the poor reviews were because the film zags from Aster’s two previous extremely haunting horrors. There is a lovingly tender animated sequence that nearly saves the film (after two slogging and haphazard initial sequences), but even by time the animated sequence concludes there is far too much film left. But out of all the films this year, it could become a classic in twenty years; it is so out there (and perhaps as people rediscover how funny the film is; is it that funny though?) and slowly piece the plot together it could be a masterpiece. Or it is a three-hour slog without a plot, weak character development, no sense of what it wanted to say and one of the worst films of the year. [Golden Globes – Best Actor Musical/Comedy Nominee], *Paramount+*.

Tier 8: Even Better Premises That Still Do Not Exactly Deliver

88. **John Wick: Chapter 4:** The film is an improvement over the third (the weakest in the series), but the franchise has lost a lot of its luster. The fight scenes are still well done (there was an emphasis on Japanese combat styles in this film), but they’ve lost the innovativeness that made the first (two) films great. At almost three hours, the film does not feel long, but the first hour is not exactly needed; seems more aimed at setting up spin-off characters. The last forty-or-so-minutes are great and really elevate the film. The looking-down-from-the-ceiling shots are amazing, the staircase fight is also great (the Arc de Triumph fight was a bit too out there for me). The second-half of the film imparts enough character development to avoid the film simply going from fight-to-fight. Who knows if the franchise will continue with Keanu Reeves, but a potential spin off with Mr. Nobody played by Shamier Anderson (*Stowaway*) might be worth making. [Critic’s Choice Super Awards – Best Action Film Winner].
87. **Wonka:** Admittedly, most of this review is of the this-was-not-the-movie-I-would-have-made type. Which is generally a weak form of criticism, but when taking established IP to make a prequel, it has some validity. The first film is partially great because outside the factory is regular life, with regular people. The factory itself is the world of pure imagination. Yet this film set in a town that does not exist; the villains are now cartoon villains (instead of ourselves, society, and parenting). The practical effects have been replaced with (at times cheap) special effects; these are especially bad in the store opening scene. The sets and costumes do look nice (when they aren’t a green screen). The songs themselves are mostly forgettable (especially when Chalamet is signing them). Luckily

Chalamet is good as Wonka when not singing and brings a youthful charm (even if there is no hint at Wonka's decent into madness; that is probably in the next film as I expect Warner to milk the franchise). Chalamet is the sole reason the film even ranks it, as it probably deserves to be a tier or two lower. [BAFTA – Best British Film Nominee], *HBOMax*.

86. **Talk to Me:** A psychological horror that isn't scary enough nor complex enough. A common theme of this years horror films, are that they are not scary. Too much focus is on the psychological trauma and not enough on the scare. The best of theses films blended the elements to both scare you and develop complex characters (or took the horror-adjacent route of not trying to be scary but use horror elements). The film does start out with a nice long tracking shot, but can't keep up the impressive visuals (in fact the film bogs down instantly afterwards and take a while to get going again). Sophie Wilde (*The Portable Door*) is good, but her traumatized character nearly ruins the movie. The trauma is a bit lazy, and is then required to drive the action; faux-organic plot development. The film's climax is a call-back to an earlier bit and comes across as lazy; a way of showing the writers took a screenwriting class without having the climax matter. The also takes the lazy way out in sound design; dialogue is often muted, so the viewer turns up the volume only for the inevitable bass being too loud. It is safe to say we are reaching the end of the Psychological Horror Renaissance. [AACTA – Best Film Winner], *Paramount+*.
85. **Limbo:** A minimalist crime investigation, that is too minimalist. The film drags at points and can not stir up much suspense. And it is a shame that the script and pacing can not keep up with the visuals and character development. The black and white cinematography is gorgeous, with the on-location setting adding another layer of amazing visuals. It is one of the best looking films of the year. But again and again it is let down by its pacing (a score would have helped). Although it is focused on the racism faced by Indigenous people in Australia, it never gets into enough depth with the characters. Director Iven Sen (*Goldstone*) makes visually appealing films, but has always lacked quality scripts to back up the visuals. [AACTA – Best Independent Film Winner].
84. **Nyad:** Annette Bening (*20th Century Women*) and Jodie Foster (*The Mauritanian*) hold the film together. The film is best when their two characters are together. The non-documentary flashbacks do not work. A lot of the solitary swimming scenes do not work. The film is far more interested in being an emotional feel-good story than really getting into the depths of Nyad's character; Bening imparts Nyad with a lot of over confidence, narcissism and asshattery (part of the reason she is so good in the film). Had the film focused more on her character than her achievements it would have made for a better film; it is one of the few that has a main character driven by spite! Instead it falls into the standard formula too often. It should also be mentioned that Alexandre Desplat is one of the best composers in the business and his score helps create a lot of the emotional impact the script is incapable of creating. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee], *Netflix*.
83. **Birth/Rebirth:** For full disclosure, my tv acted up while watching so I had to take a few pauses and perhaps that got me out of the film. As I wished it was better. it had an interesting premise; two women keeping a girl alive – for wildly different reasons – one for science, the other for love. Marin Ireland (*The Dark and the Wicked*) and Judy Reyes (*Scrubs*) are rather good and able to guide the film thru their characters. Although marketed as a horror, the film has nearly zero scares [Massive Digression: I've been saying for years horror is the best genre in film. As people finally caught on, too many films on this list are marketed as horrors without being horrors; they may have a few horror elements, but they are not horrors], and does not do as much as it could with its *Frankenstein* set up. Co-written and directed by Laura Moss is her debut, and perhaps if the film was more of a straight drama it would have succeeded more. [Independent Spirit – Best Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.
82. **El Conde:** A film with a fun premise: what if Pinochet was a 250-year-old vampire. It does get a little bit of comedy out of the idea, but soon enough it runs out of steam. Paula Luchsinger puts in

a star-making role, and one hopes she'll be able to do English-language films as she has the talent to be a leading lady. Directed by Pablo Larraín (*Jackie* and *Spencer*), like his earlier films they are well-made but often slog. Besides Luchsinger, the standout is the black-and-white cinematography. The flying sequences are absolutely gorgeous and what earned the film its nominations. The entire film looks good, but often non aw-inducing like some of the other recent cinematography nominees. [Oscars – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Netflix*.

81. **The Color Purple:** I can't believe I am saying this, but the film needed to embrace being a musical. There are some musical numbers, but the film exists in the uncanny valley where it isn't a musical, but it also isn't a film that happens to have musical numbers. Some of the numbers seem cut short, other times it seems the scene avoided the song all together but kept a brief dance to advance the plot (disclaimer: I have never seen the musical). The best two musical sequences are the number on the record player (which seemed cut short!) and the art deco dance number (which also seemed cut short!). The various actresses are all good, but they are not standouts. Colman Domingo was certainly an interesting casting choice as Mister. It is not nearly as good as Spielberg's 1985 version; mainly because Spielberg was able to give the film an impeccable visual style with his shot composition and editing. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actress Nominee], *HBOMax*.
80. **Enys Men:** An experimental horror written, directed, photographed, edited, and scored by Mark Jenkin (*Bait*). Note: Enys Men is Cornish for Stone Island. The experimental nature could move the film down a tier (or two) if the view finds the film a slow bore, or if able to stay fully engaged, it could move up a tier. The film is shot to purposely give it the feel of those 70s folk horror films. And the retro visuals help keep the view entranced during a slow start (the film is also gorgeously shot; landscapes, framing, and closeup). The final twenty minutes allow the film to come together, but staying engaged for all 95 minutes can be difficult; the more attention paid, the more callbacks that can be spotted. The film plays with time, memory, and existence in some nice ways. There are multiple interpretations of the film. The horror is not scary, but psychological and in some ways the film is more of an experimental drama about isolation and loneliness. [British Independent Film – Best Sound Winner], *Hulu*.
79. **Pretty Red Dress:** An enjoyable indie that had a far bit to say about identity. The film is one of the more unique when it comes to gender identity, and one wishes it explored the character of the father (played by Natey Jones who was good). The film does not come together as well as it could (even if Natey Jones gives a great speech at the climax). A little more expansion of why the father was in prison would have been nice, and the interactions with his older brother are hit and miss. It was the film feature film from writer-director Dionne Edwards, and hopefully her next effort is better as this film had the right ingredients to be much higher, but it didn't come together the way the top films of the year do. [British Independent Film – Best Supporting Performance Nominee].
78. **The Wrath of Becky:** A fun follow-up to *Becky* that manages to improve upon the original. The kills are still gory and inventive. However this film added more comedy and therefore a better overall tone, while also incorporating that the titular Becky is now sixteen instead of fourteen. Seann William Scott (*American Pie*) is good as the leader of the alt-right men's group. I hope they make a third film, as these are enjoyable. A girl killing Nazis and Nazi-adjacent men's rights members is an enjoyable evening. It, much like the original, could get into a little more character development and refine the social commentary a bit. [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Paramount+*.
77. **Leave the World Behind:** The film looks good, with a lot of cool shots/camera movement within the house where most of the film is shot; written and directed by Sam Esmail (*Mr. Robot*). The biggest flaw is the ending, with Mahershala Ali (*Swan Song*) explaining to Ethan Hawke/the audience what is going on, complete with the obvious social commentary. The next flaw is the lack of character development. Although the cast is good, they aren't given much in the way of characters beyond I'm-not-trusting or I-go-with-the-flow. Strangers-holding-up-together-during-the-apocalypse is a classic

genre, and this one is not able to get much new out of it; beyond great actors and stylish direction. The other major flaw is that the film plays fast and loose with Long Island/New York geography. Although it bogs down a bit at times, it quickly finds a new quirk to explore. Also, I approve of all defenses of owning physical media. [Well-reviewed Drama], *Netflix*.

76. **Brooklyn 45:** A horror-adjacent drama; going in expecting the seance to be a driving force of scares will be disappointed (there are legit body horror shots). The cast is rather good, but needed to be great to move the film into the next tier. Ezra Buzzington is solid, though borders on overacting. Larry Fessenden (*Dashcam*, *Jakob's Wife*, *The Dead Don't Die*, and *We Are Still Here*) continues his string of solid work in indie horrors. The works as a chamber play as the characters are slowly developed and the themes of war make for good fodder. Though even at 90 minutes, some themes are hammered home with on-the-nose monologues. But given the runtime, if those were cut the film is then barely 75 minutes (and they could put the film lower they are that bad). The film shows that once again Ted Geoghegan (*We Are Still Here*) makes solid low-budget horrors. [Well-reviewed Horror].
75. **Biosphere:** Mark Duplass (*Language Lessons*) continues his string of under-the-radar films. The film has only two characters played by Mark Duplass and Sterling K Brown and the only set is the titular biosphere. The film does a good job of slowly informing the audience of who the characters are and why they are in the biosphere. But the film does struggle at times with its limited setting and character (it frequently relies on two or three re-occurring jokes/references in their lives). The lengthily opening tracking shot of the two running around the biosphere (ala *2001*), but that ends up being about it for well composed shots. The film develops the characters (figuratively and literally), but with an interesting and unique premise you end up wishing it was able to get more out of said premise. That the film could have been multiple tiers higher if it had figured a few things out. [Well-reviewed Science Fiction], *Hulu*.
74. **Cocaine Bear:** A delight of a B-movie. Even if one wishes the budget was a few million dollars more to make the bear look more realistic, and there were a few more jokes, it still is dumb fun. Directors get credit when they assemble all-star casts, and Elizabeth Banks (*Charlie's Angels*) deserves a round of applause for not only getting a great cast, but getting a great cast for a B-movie: Keri Russell, O'Shea Jackson Jr. (*Straight Outta Compton*), Ray Liotta (*Marriage Story*), Isiah Whitlock Jr. (*The Wire*), Brooklynn Prince (*The Florida Project*), and Margo Martindale (*Uncle Frank*), among others. One does wish their names were not listed in the opening credit so as to be surprised when all of these great actors keep showing up. Have a few beers, or some mushrooms, or acid, and enjoy 96 zany minutes of fun. [A Bear Does Cocaine and Kills People], *Amazon Prime*.

Tier 7: Decent Biopics, Inventive-Enough Sci-Fi, and Fun

73. **Missing:** Although the duo behind *Searching*, were involved the film was written and directed by new people. It has the same visual style (of being images from character's computers, phones, and other smart devices). Whereas I loved the stylistic innovation with *Searching*, the second time around it fell flat; once was enough. If you can still get enjoyment from the set up, it can rank a tier higher. The plot is still good and keeps up the thrills. There are enough (logical) twists and turns to keep the audience on their heels (much like the first film). The set up makes it difficult for actors truly shine but Storm Reid is able to keep the film going thru any lulls. More of these films might work – it helps that they've nearly perfected the stand alone aspect – but the 'gimmick' might be close to running its course. [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Netflix*.
72. **The Inventor:** A low-budget stop-motion animated that has more than enough charm to hide its flaws and production budget. The score by Alex Mandel is secretly great (and his songs are enjoyable as well). The film often blends multiple animation styles (stop-motion, puppetry, watercolor, etc);

some of the transitions are extremely good (the ‘animated’ illustration of what happens if Da Vinci makes war machines), while others seem like they are trying to save money. There are plenty of laughs (that continue into and thru the credits). [Annie Awards – Best Independent Film Nominee].

71. **Juniper:** Charlotte Rampling (*Georgy Girl*) is extremely good and holds the simple film together. There are essentially four characters, and the film shows how they each deal with death and grief. Each character is given enough development to overcome a basic plot. George Ferrier is rather good and matches wits with Rampling’s character. The film benefits from its on-location New Zealand landscapes; the rolling hills and sunrises look amazing. It is a good debut from writer-director Matthew J. Saville. Though again, the film is Rampling’s. [Well-reviewed Drama].
70. **Blackberry:** The primary issue is that director Matt Johnson had only done found-footage and mockumentary films before this one. And the style continues; camera peering through windows, shaking as it moves to the other character talking. The style completely take you out of the production. It wasn’t needed and it only detracted (if it doesn’t annoy you, the film can easily move up a tier). The make-up is iffy as Jim Balsillie’s bald spot looked fake; thankfully Glenn Howerton was rather good in the role. However the film excels at showing the rise and fall of the infamous phone, with specific details instead of a generic overview. It also details the technical issues with phones and the internet; something few films about the tech industry can pull-off. The film does pull off the feel of the era(s), but mainly does it through licensing rather than solid set and costume design. The time jumps mainly work, but the final jump to 2007 fails to show how characters changed in the last four years. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *Hulu*.
69. **Ferarri:** A lot of my review for *Gran Turismo* applies here; films about racing need to embrace what makes racing fun. Honestly *Ford vs Ferrari* was a complete game changer in this regard, and I should go back and rewatch it. Especially with Ferarri on the verge of bankruptcy, it could have done a better job of the economics of racing (‘the only way to make a small fortune in racing, is to start with a large fortune’). The film itself is usually technically excellent, except for the VFX. Frequently the VFX look bad, real bad; that dramatic wrecks end up being comical. Adam Driver is decent, and Penelope Cruz is rather good. Cruz should have gotten more awards buzz. The film could have been a lot better, instead it is one of the yearly Oscar-bait films that falls flat. But given it has Adam Driver and racing, I probably liked it more than I should have. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film], *Hulu*.
68. **The Creator:** A film that probably got a bad rap given its odd marketing campaign, as it is a decent sci-fi film. The effects are good (but the fine details of spacecraft and the like are often missing), what is especially nice is that the film eschews the familiar loud and fire explosions for more realistic action. Though it plays fast and loose with physics and logic at times. One wishes it provided a little bit more background; the United States is 15-years into a war on human-like AI yet why is the war still going on? why has the US not simply bombed the AI out of existence? (one assumes this is a comment about US involvement in the Middle East(?) but those parallels never come thru). The idea of the plot is good and has a lot of good themes yet the script can not put all of them together in a fully satisfactory manner. This is a film you’ll want to like even more, but at each turn it will do something that fails to elevate it. [Oscars – Best Sound Nominee], *Hulu*.
67. **Guardians of the Galaxy Vol 3:** In what is presumably the final installment in the *Guardians* franchise (or at least the franchise as we’ve known it) the film does a good job in wrapping it up. It might be better than *Vol 1*, but it is such a hard call to make as the first brought such a breath of fresh air to the MCU with its jokes and off-beat everything. The issue with this film is that everything outside of the Rocket plot is inferior; although serving as a Rocket origin story, the film also needs to wrap up the franchise (with the option of continuing with ‘new’ Guardians who have been introduced in this film). Although the over-the-top MCU fight sequences are still there, they are

not as heavy-handed as other recent entries. But again, they detract from the Rocket plot. [Oscars – Best Visual Effects Nominee], *Disney+*.

66. **Dream Scenario:** A difficult film to rank. The first half is a top-ten film of the year. Except in the second half it completely runs out of steam and starts grasping at straws. It did not know how to wrap up its ingenious premise; everyone(?) starts seeing lowly Biology Professor [played by Nic Cage] in their dreams, while he stands there doing nothing (often while something bad happens to them). Firstly, Nic Cage is a god. He is amazing in the film and single-handedly carries during the start of the second-half downturn (eventually the script runs out of ideas and he can no longer help). The scene when Cage only wants to pitch his academic book, and not become an influencer is a great joke about academics. The supporting cast is decent; Dylan Gelula (*First Girl I Loved*) always deserves a shout out. It is a shame the film never realized how it wanted to end, as it was onto something. [Golden Globes – Best Actor Musical/Comedy Nominee], *HBOMax*.
65. **Mad Heidi:** We need more B-movies. B-movies are fun; especially low-budget B-movies that punch far above their weight. Take the children’s classic Heidi and now make the Swiss government ran by a fascist dictator (who also runs a cheese company!). There are references to multiple other films (including an enjoyable *Starship Troopers*; also about fascism!). The film over-the-top and 90 minutes of fun. Alice Lucy is good an Heidi, but it is difficult to tell if she has star potential or if the film is simply so absurd you have a good time—but I hope she is given the chance to show her talents. [Well-reviewed Action].
64. **Dicks: The Musical:** We really need more B-movies. Even musical B-movies! The film is a crisp 86 minutes with Nathan Lane (*The Lion King*) and Megan Mullally (*Will & Grace*). Both of whom carry the film thru any lulls. Each is a comedic genius and without them, the film would not work. The film leans into the absurdity with zany and off-the-walls gags. If you buy into the film, the gags are mainly enjoyable. Other cast members include Bowen Yang and Megan Thee Stallion., each of whom is funny. Veteran Larry Charles (*Seinfeld*, *Curb Your Enthusiasm*, and *Borat*) directs, and I am interested what writers and leads Josh Sharp and Aaron Jackson do next. [Well-reviewed Comedy], *HBOMax*.
63. **Linoleum:** In a film with Rhea Seehorn (*Better Call Saul*) and Jim Gaffigan (*Hot Pockets*), somehow the chemistry between the ‘kids’ Katelyn Nacon (*Too Many Cooks*) and Gabriel Rush (actually a single episode of *Better Call Saul*) is better (Seehorn and Gaffigan are both delightful as to be expected). One wishes those characters were developed a little more; their late-night adventure is the second-best sequence in the film with excellent editing. The ending is amazing, but sadly too drawn out. The script also spells a few too many things out directly, with characters saying what they feel (even it is obvious the characters are feeling that). but the cast is good enough those issues can be ignored. One wishes the film was tighter as it had real potential to move up multiple tiers with a few improvements. The guts were there and I’m interested in what writer-director Colin West does next. [Well-reviewed Science Fiction], *Hulu*.
62. **You Are So Not Invited to My Bat Mitzvah:** Sunny Sandler and Samantha Lorraine are talented enough to carry the film through its semi-predictable and semi-standard coming-of-age moments; two friends have a falling out but *technically a spoiler* reunite before the end credits. The reunion is heart-felt and moving (as moving as a YA film can get). There are a few Gen Z criticisms that fall flat, but it also brings a few modern touches to coming-of-age. Adam Sandler (*Uncut Gems*) presumably plays himself and is remarkable in that he steps back and allows his daughters (and wife) to shine—he still manages to get in a few Sandler-isms (all while rocking Hawaiian shirts and overly-large basketball shorts). One does wish Idina Menzel (*Uncut Gems*) had an opportunity to cook. Overall it is new-enough with potential stars-in-the-make that it overcomes any flaws. [Well-reviewed Drama], *Netflix*.

61. **Leo:** The semi-simple animated film ends up having a lot going for it. The premise of a talking lizard (voiced by Adam Sandler, who's voice acting is rather good) giving live advice to confused fifth graders could have been dull and sappy the film never is. There are enough jokes for kids and kids alike. There is enough (basic) social commentary; with the right level of ridicule aimed at parents (one of whom is voiced by Jason Alexander). The animation is good, but not great. Somehow, the film threads all the needles and ends up being a great example of what we should expect from animated films that are aimed towards kids and adults. [Annie Awards – Best Editing Nominee], *Netflix*.
60. **Emily:** I have not read *Wuthering Heights* (nor seen any screen adaptations). Nor did I know anything about Emily Brontë. Therefore I wasn't exactly the audience for the film, but the multiple historic liberties did not bother me (as I didn't know they were being taken). As I assume that people who enjoy *Wuthering Heights* will get a lot more out of the film than I did (as the film is essentially the lead up to Emily writing the novel). Emma Mackey (*Death on the Nile*) is rather good as a mildly recluse and frequently scorned Emily. One wishes they did more with the younger sister Anne (played by Amelia Gething who showed some potential). The costumes and sets were nothing special, but nicely done (any historic drama needs a mention of the costumes). The film wasn't slow, but it never wraps you in (again this could simply be me not know/caring about the real-life characters; I haven't read *Jane Eyre* either). [British Independent Film – Best Lead Nominee], *Hulu*.
59. **Lola:** Co-written and directed by Andrew Legge in his directorial debut. The film is a great blend of found-footage and sci-fiction/time-travel. Emma Appleton and Stefanie Martini are both good as the co-leading sisters. One wishes in the second half of the film Appleton's character was given more development (but given the found footage 'limitations' that would have been difficult; most of the shots are from Martini's character film home videos). The black-and-white 16mm looks good, and the filmed newsreel footage looks realistic; one even believes it was real. The film explores familiar themes involving time travel, but with the added layer of the ethics involved; especially if trying to end WWII sooner. It would be hard to expand on its 85 minute runtime given the found-footage limitation, but a few more scenes would have been enjoyable and this was an enjoyable low-budget indie. [Well-reviewed Sci-fi], *Peacock*.
58. **Lonesome:** A gay movie that is unabashed when it comes to depicting gay sex. There are three different sex scenes in the first five minutes (and more as the film progresses). In a genre with lots of films, too many shy away from the sexual nature of their characters. Part of the film's ranking here is because of its 'graphic' nature. The other part of its high ranking is the characters. Both leads are well-developed and opposite ends of the out experience. The film does tell a few too many things (the worst offense being when the lady explicitly says she hires them to atone for her failed relationship with her own gay son; it was implied and a nice moment that was ruined). There are a few too many dream sequences, and even at 95 minutes it can feel slow at a few times. But what still remains is a good story about a young gay man forced to flee to the big city and find his way and hope to make it on his own. [AACTA – Best Independent Film Nominee].
57. **Asteroid City:** Written and directed by Wes Anderson in what is his weakest effort since either *Darjeeling Limited* or *Life Aquatic* (I was one of the few that loved *French Dispatch*). The film has his standard trademarks of top-notch production design and cinematography. Yet, this film lacks a lot of the charm and quirkiness that make his films unique; the film is short on laughs. Beyond being short on laughs, it also lacks a lot of character development. The film brings back multiple Anderson stalwarts, and a few new fresh faces (Maya Hawke and Sophia Lillis being the best; Steve Carell was also an excellent last-minute Bill Murray fill-in). The film's meta set up is not the issue, the problem is the characters are weakly developed so therefore little of the action and plot becomes meaningful. [Critic's Choice – Best Production Design Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

Tier 6: Good Movies

56. **Elemental:** A film that is difficult to rank. The animation is absolutely amazing. Pixar spent 200 million and the end result is gorgeous. The fire people, subtly change color, and have realistic looking flames. There are multiple scenes with running water and each looks amazing. The film even goes all-in with a scene or two on a beach with sand; one even begins to think Pixar was showing off. Any scene with the glass creating looks gorgeous. From a purely-animation stand point, it is probably the best animated film of the year. Except the plot is a little basic and predictable. Leah Lewis (*The Half of It*) and Mamoudou Athie (*Jean of the Joneses*) are good as the two voice leads, especially Lewis. It ends up being a gorgeous-yet-standard film about immigrant families. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Disney+*.
55. **Chevalier:** A biopic that doesn't quite figure out what it wants to say about its main character; outside of Chevalier de Saint-Georges was a talented composer who was still constrained in life by being black. The film lacks a lot of subtlety, his motivations are usually obvious. Kelvin Harrison Jr. (*Luce* and *Waves*) is rather good, but again limited by the lack of depth given to his character. Samara Weaving (*Ready or Not*) is a delight as always and one is glad to see her as a serious co-lead. Lucy Boynton (*Sing Street*) is decent as well. Costumes and sets are rather nice, as you'd hope from a French Revolution piece. [Black Reel – Best Lead Nominee], *Hulu*.
54. **Are Your There God? It's Me, Margaret:** The film succeeds by being one of the few coming-of-age films about girls, and particular middle school girls. While most films in this genre are set in high school with high school problems, this is far more naive and innocent as the characters are about 12. (*Good Boys* is perhaps the closest thing, but that is about boys and far less innocent). All four of the girls perform admirably though none really stand out in their roles (Elle Graham does the most acting, but mainly because her character is over-the-top; Katherine Kupferer will be a star, but that is because I've seen her in another film on the 2024 list). Rachel McAdams (*mean Girls*) is good and her character is almost as central to the film (and could have even used a little more attention). The film doesn't have lofty goals, but it accomplishes everything it wants it to in a tidy feel-good package. [WGA – Best Adapted Screenplay Nominee].
53. **Showing Up:** Co-written and directed by Kelly Reichardt (*First Cow*). The film has her hallmark slice-of-life slow pacing. A style that can quickly become off-putting and this film nearly veers into that territory at times. The cinematography is rather weak as the film is frequently grainy (use higher-quality film stock! get the lighting right!; you are not being artistic, you are being lazy). Speaking of slice-of-life there are far too many shots of the 'students' at the art school. These are not needed (also their art isn't that good). Michelle Williams is great as always. Her character is given a lot of depth, but too much of the character's development is mirrored by a wounded bird subplot; one does not even need to be an astute viewer to pick up on the similarities. The script itself is very good, as relationships and background are slowly revealed. The score is wonderful but only played at the start and end, a real missed opportunity. Perhaps if the art in the film looked better it would be more engaging; there is a undercurrent of potential jealousy but none of the art looks good (or is it suppose to be about the randomness of success; that isn't clear either). It is a good film, but it could have been better [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *Paramount+*.
52. **Tetris:** A film that is far more fun than you'd expect. It has a whimsy that for the most part it manages to maintain even as the film gets serious; both thanks to Taron Edgerton (*Rocketman*) and to the frequent use of 8-bit graphics. The film does end up taking a few too many historic liberties, but they do not derail the film. The minor characters are given enough develop to keep the film going. The film has an endearing pro-(legal-)entrepreneurial spirit (property rights are important!) that isn't often seen; it is unabashedly pro-American (and not in a MAGA-way), but rather highlighting all of what makes America actually great; freedom, opportunity, and diversity. It also helps that Edgerton

is so enjoyable in the leading role and pulls of buffoonery, honesty, and desire. [Critic's Choice Super Awards – Best Actor in a Superhero(?!?) Movie Nominee], *AppleTV+*.

51. **Rustin:** The film veers too much into history lesson than biopic; Bayard Rustin a gay black man is a leader in the Civil Rights Movement. Yet the film is frequently more interested in how the March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom was organized rather than Rustin's life. Although it does get at his life, it often takes a back seat (or is used to complicate the organization of the march; it might be a failure because it is organized by a homosexual!). Now most negatives can be easily ignored as Colman Domingo (*Ma Rainey's Black Bottom*) is excellent. He deserves every Best Actor nomination he'll receive. [Oscars – Best Actor Nominee], *Netflix*.
50. **Priscilla:** This is Cailee Spaeny's (*How It Ends*) film. She is rather good, and it is a bit of a shame she didn't get more award recognition (perhaps A24 put its might behind other films). She especially nails the young doe-eyed Priscilla. And the script gives reasons for her and Elvis to fall in love; they are both lonely and missing home while in Germany. Yet, when she moves in to Graceland the film quickly becomes one you've seen a hundred times about a woman realizing the man of her dreams isn't what she expected; controlling, abusive, a drug addict, never home, constantly cheating. The film is not over-the-top on these, and it does try to balance it out with a few moments of love. But it is still one you've seen, and whereas *Elvis* made Elvis out to be sympathetic (his dad and The Colonel cause his problems), this film is the polar opposite and lays all the blame on Elvis (neither really works; and The Colonel is never seen in this one). The costumes for Priscilla are very good, though the same can't be said for the other characters. The film needs to span 12-plus years and some of the edits are rather good, other are lazy. It still ends up being a solid film and a huge improvement over the previous year's *Elvis*. [Golden Globes – Best Actress Musical/Comedy Nominee], *HBOMax*.
49. **Napoleon:** Ridley Scott's (*The Last Duel* and *House of Gucci*) late-career has been bumpy to say the least. The three best parts of the film are: battle scenes, costumes, and sets. All of which were enhanced by the Dolby Cinema screening I went to. The winter battle is amazing, and one of the better spectacles of the year. As the film is spectacle. The plot has massive time gaps which cause the now-unfolding events to have little sense of place. The characterization is minimal, at best. The historical inaccuracies are fine, because shooting cannonballs at the pyramids looks awesome. Perhaps the alleged 4-hour director's cut will fill in some gaps, or worse it will make the film bog down even more. As the film bogs down frequently, but a battle soon follows and the viewer is once again in awe. [Oscars – Best Production Design Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
48. **Of An Age:** Written, directed, and edited by Goran Stolevski in his English-language debut. In an attempt to create a feeling of intimacy the film features constant close ups, and they do get annoying. The lead performances of Elias Anton and Thom Green and both good, but not great enough to elevate the film through some iffy dialogue; leading to the film dragging at times. Hattie Hook's character serves to advance the plot, but is written as such a chaotic mess that makes the film grating (if one can tolerate the character's craziness the film can rank higher; it also takes far too long to explain why they would be friends with her and even then the explanation is rather weak). The film does avoid a lot of pitfalls of the coming-of-age gay genre, but also doesn't find much new to say. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
47. **Brother:** A film I wish I liked more. The cinematography is rather good with the framing, angles, and lighting being the best parts. The film is set over three time periods and weaves between all three rather well, and slowly reveals key plot points. Perhaps the main knock is the runtime, as at two-hours it doesn't feel long, but rather given all that time you'd want more character development. There still is a good deal, but not as much as there could have been. Although the leads are both good, the actors are far too old to be playing high school students (the one was 28 during filming) so when the time frames are a little ambiguous when actors do not look the age the characters they are

playing it detracts (ironically the biggest offender is Aaron Pierre who is best known as the rapper in *Old*). [Black Reel – Best International Film Nominee].

46. **Society of the Snow:** Directed and co-written by J. A. Bayona (*The Impossible*), the takes a lot of understated choices; these are not bad (not exactly amazing either), but unique. The film has little interest in sensationalizing the story of the stranded rugby players. The plane crash and avalanche scenes both are perfect examples and two great scenes. The film has a large ensemble cast, and does a decent job of balancing the sheer number of characters (most are able to get some development, but when there are 20+ characters it is difficult). The film also excels by not explaining the necessary survival choices; rather it shows the audience how they collected drinking water and made sunglasses (the sun reflects off the snow like crazy). There are or two great speeches. The make-up was rather good; as it showed them starving, freezing, and decaying. It is one of the better survival movies in recent times and cements Bayona as a master of the survival genre. [Oscars – Best Makeup Nominee], *Netflix*.
45. **Suzume:** Written and directed by Makoto Shinkai (*Your Name* and *Weathering With You*), it seems that he is mainly repeating themes. A girl and boy must team up to prevent disasters. It is still different enough, but the general idea still seems the same. The supporting characters are still all good. The animation is often good, but some of the computer-animated parts look bad; especially when contrasted with the rest of the film. His films are still worth watching, as they are often technically excellent with good characters. Yet, you hope his next film does not follow the now-familiar formula. [Annie Awards – Best Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
44. **Passages:** Co-written and directed by Ira Sachs (*Keep the Lights On*, *Love is Strange*, and *Little Men*), the film itself is beautiful. There are many long takes, there is one shot in a diner that makes excellent use of mirrors and might be one of the most visually interesting shots all year (the cars ‘change’ direction in the background due to the reflection of the mirror). All three leads are rather good: Franz Rogowski, Ben Whishaw, and Adèle Exarchopoulos each are amazing. Perhaps the only draw back is the Rogowski’s character drives the action but his character is the least developed; we never quite see why he makes his choices, but only that he keeps making the wrong ones (being a cocky director wasn’t enough background for me). The film also features two of the best-filmed sex scenes of the year (and in recent memory). The script does a great job showing and not telling while jumping thru time as the various relationships crumble. It is a film I wish I could have liked more, but it never did enough to be in the upper echelons for this year. [Independent Spirit – Best Film Nominee].
43. **Fremont:** A simplistic film that provides a fresh look at the immigrant experience. Co-written and directed by Babak Jalali, the film is held together by a string of great performances and gorgeous cinematography. Shot in black-and-white the film looks amazing. Newcomer Anaita Wali Zada steals the show with her subtle mannerisms. She is instantly one to watch. Gregg Turkington (*Gravity Falls*) is excellent as a psychiatrist and brings a wry sense of humor to the film (even if his scenes veer a little too much with telling-not-showing). Jeremy Allen White is one of the best actors on the planet (how did such a low-budget film get him?!) and he has perfected playing a dead-inside-but-optimistic character. He speaks so few lines but he conveys such depth and makes the film so touching. One wishes there was more to get out of its 90-minute runtime, but what is there was overlooked and worth watching. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award Winner].
42. **The Starling Girl:** One wishes the film was better as Eliza Scanlen (*Babyteeth*) is that good; she really deserves to lead a major film. Lewis Pullman (*Top Gun: Maverick*) is also good. Yet, the film covers familiar coming-of-age territory; teenager in relationship with an older man and strict religious communities. Within these two subgenres it doesn’t bring much new. Some of the particular details regarding the religious community are good. The supporting characters could use more development;

why the older man wants to leave his wife for a teenager is developed, but a scene of their home life would be useful. Her father is an alcoholic so the viewer can piece together why he married/converted but more background would be useful. The film is also hurt by having two climaxes, moving the first climax up and showing more of aftermath would have been helpful. Still the overall film is good and Scanlen is a talent. [Independent Spirit – Best First Screenplay Nominee], *Paramount+*.

41. **The Royal Hotel:** One of the few films on the list that you wish was longer. The film is a tight 90 minutes, but you wished that more time was spent on the character's background (eventually the film reveals why they are in Australia, but even that only explains a little bit). Julia Garner (*The Assistant*) and Jessica Henwick (*Love and Monsters*) are both rather good. The film was co-written and directed by Kitty Green (*The Assistant*), who has now established herself as a good director with two straight solid films with complex female characters in precarious situations (and both films I wished were longer!). Whatever Kitty Green does next, sign me up. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee], *Hulu*.
40. **The Burial:** Jamie Foxx (*Just Mercy*) had an extremely underrated year (outside of the Black Reel Awards where he was rightly nominated for both Best Actor and Best Supporting Actor for his work this year). Foxx holds the film together as the (former) ambulance chasing lawyer Willie Gary. Foxx brings a charm that is needed to the role that few people can. Tommy Lee Jones is solid as Foxx's unlikely client. The film does veer too much into standard courtroom drama tropes at times (last minute revelations and witness breakdowns; though when it is Bill Camp is works). Despite those flaws in the script it still has a few good jokes, and has enough to say about race relations. In many ways, it is a good example of what a general audience good film can be. It is nothing special but well made (even if it could have captured the early 90s a little better), with good acting and solid character development. [Black Reel – Best Lead Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
39. **Infinity Pool:** Written and directed by Brandon Cronenberg (*Possessor*), he continues making thought-provoking and out-there films ala his father. Mia Goth (*X* and *Pearl*) continues to show that she is one of the best actresses on the planet; especially when playing an off-kilter character. With another lead actress the film almost certainly falls flat as Goth's character needs to seduce Alexander Skarsgård's (*The Northman*) (married) character and then lead him down a path a perversion (Author's Note: sign me up!). Skarsgård is good, but not great, again it is Mia Goth's film. The themes surrounding ethics, sexual fantasies, and wealth inequality are decent, but at times too straight-forward (even if presented to the audience in a new and freaky way). [Critic's Choice Super Awards – Best Actress in a Horror Nominee], *Hulu*.

Tier 5: Somewhere in this Tier, We Reach Recommended Regardless Territory

38. **All Dirt Roads Taste of Salt:** One of the hardest films to rank, as it is one of the most experimental of the year (think Terrence Malick), which I did not know going in (and wasn't exactly in the mood for that style of film). The film itself is slow, with little dialogue. The character development can be difficult to follow as the plot is non-linear with almost no exposition (I will admit it was difficult for me to track who was who give then time jumps; which sister is which, or is it now their mother or are they adults? teens?). The sound design is amazing; rain and streams are important themes and they each sound amazing (one benefit of minimal dialogue is these sounds can take center stage). The cinematography is gorgeous; the camera intimately lingers on hands, ribbons in hair, the wilderness, etc. Most every shot is beautifully composed and long. However the lengthy shots also contribute to the film being slow. Raven Jackson made a unique film in her directorial debut, and one that I'd be most interested in rewatching. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee].
37. **The Killer:** Directed by David Fincher, the film is good, but one hopes for better given who's directing it and that it stars Michael Fassbender (*Shame*). Fassbender plays an elite hitman, and

frequently provides (iffy) voiceovers. The film often feels like *John Wick* crossed with *American Psycho*. One wishes it was more original. The source material is a graphic novel, which I assume is post-modernist given the voiceovers and pop culture references (the killer's aliases are all sitcom characters; Robert Hartley and Sam Malone being my favorite). Tilda Swinton makes a brief appearance and is a delight as always. One almost wishes the film was Fassbender and Swinton talking for two hours. Yet, Fincher creates a thrilling-enough thriller that never bogs, even if it frequently plays it too safe. [Critic's Choice Super Awards – Best Actor in a Superhero (?!) Movie Nominee], *Netflix*.

36. **Reality:** All of the dialogue is taken word-for-word from a public FBI transcript of an interview that takes place of the course of an afternoon. Debut director and technically writer Tina Satter manages to get great cinematic value out of what is essentially a three-person chamber play (with a pre-written script!). The film reminds the viewer the dialogue is all read (at times cutting to the transcript, or the transcript being typed), or cuts to the audio recording itself, and even makes innovative use of the redacted sections. All of these give added depth to a film that could have easily been a dud while allowing the performs to provide the added realism of interpreting the actual dialogue. Josh Hamilton (*Eighth Grade*) is absolutely fantastic as one of the FBI agents; he switches from caring, to introspective, to potentially manipulative easily. Again, using the actual dialogue, he then creates a fully developed character. However the real star, and the instant star of everything she's in, is Sydney Sweeney. She is amazing, and although she can crush cutesy/funny dramedy, she is beyond talented enough to carry a drama. [PGA – Best Streaming Movie Nominee], *HBOMax*.
35. **Eileen:** Set in winter late-60s New England, the film unfortunately had to compete with *The Holdovers* given their similarities of time and location. Now the set design and costumes were still rather good, simply not as good as *The Holdovers*. The reason the film ranks here is that Anne Hathaway and Thomasin McKenzie are both amazing. McKenzie plays her mildly-naive and sexually curious character perfectly. While Hathaway nails her strong independent woman character. William Oldroyd (*Lady Macbeth*) once again gets great performances out of his leading ladies. In fact one wishes the film spent more time developing their relationship; a 100 minute movie could have easily been two hours. The film does go off the rails at the end (another reason to have the film be longer is that the final act could have been set up more) and in doing so drags down the ranking (and for some could drag it down even more). Though in going off the rails, it sets up an amazing monologue by Marin Ireland (*Birth/Rebirth*) that nearly steals the show from the two leads. Had the film set up the final act, it could have ranked much higher. [Independent Spirit – Best Director Nominee], *Hulu*.
34. **American Fiction:** The film suffers from wanting to have its cake and eat it. A film that is too on-the-nose about being too on-the-nose. It is the weakest Best Picture Nominee (ironically the nomination makes on more critical when watching and the flaws become apparent). A fair bit of the jokes land, and not exactly the jokes that are meant to be funny (again it is too tongue-in-cheek). Luckily the film develops its characters and the leads are solid; Jeffery Wright and Sterling K Brown being the best of the bunch. Wright especially makes the main character balanced enough (except there another film, higher on this list, with a similar character that is portrayed even better). It also helps that the script sets up a lot of later developments, but those risk spoilers. The scene when the characters 'come to life' and act out the 'novel' being written is rather good. But at the end it comes across as a satire of a satire of a satire, and it can't pull it off. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
33. **Polite Society:** Nida Manzoor's debut feature film (she wrote and directed). Some of the stylistic choices in the directing hamper the film (a large number of homages to kung-fu movies, which I personally have never liked). Thankfully the script itself is rather funny, and usually the proper amount of bizarre. The film is bolstered by Priya Kansara and Ritu Arya (*Umbrella Academy*) in

the main roles; each are rather funny in addition to the script. Ella Bruccoleri is perhaps the real find, as she is hilarious in her supporting role as a socially-awkward high-school friend; I don't know if she'll have the talent to be a leading lady, but I hope she gets more supporting roles as quirky characters. The film is a little predictable, but it brings enough new material to multiple familiar premises. [British Independent Film – Best Debut Screenplay Winner], *Amazon Prime*.

32. **Memory:** Written and directed by Michel Franco (*Chronic*), the film is a showcase for Jessica Chastain (*Zero Dark Thirty*) and Peter Sarsgaard (*An Education*). Chastain is amazing as always and she effortlessly acts; she never overdoes it but still gives her character such emotion even over the simple things; paging up a repair man, lock doors, etc. That Chastain puts in a nomination-worthy performance every year, with wildly different characters is a testament to her dedication and talent. Sarsgaard is also effortlessly charming and aloof, which is what his dementia-afflicted character requires. One wishes Sarsgaard's character was developed a bit more; beyond rich, has dementia, and doesn't exactly get along with his family. Chastain's character has a fair bit of development, but the income inequality aspect could have been developed. It is a moving film about two damaged people coming together, played by two great actors. [Independent Spirit – Best Lead Performance Nominee].
31. **When Evil Lurks:** An Argentinian horror film that packs a few scares. Too many of the 'horror' films on this list have no legit scares (and this could be as good a place as any to lament that the horror genre is not as good as it used to be). It creates an interesting world (even if there was some required exposition on how the 'evil' works). There are some themes about family, loss, and grief but the film can't bring all of the home. Had the themes landed better it might be able to move into the next tier. A few of the shots look rather nice. Other people might get more out of it, as the film does rely on parent-child relationship a lot and makes use of children being evil. [Critic's Choice Super Awards – Best Horror Nominee], *Hulu*.
30. **Theater Camp:** Possibly the most-fun 90-minutes of the year. You wish it was even longer. Ayo Edebiri (*The Bear*) has a small role as last-minute hire who lied on their resume; knowing almost nothing about acting or theater. She steals each scene she is in, and you wished she was in more and had her character developed. I wonder if Ayo was recruited by co-writer and co-director Molly Gordon who has a smaller role on *The Bear*. The songs are rather good, and one almost wished an Oscar campaign was waged for *Woman Can't Read* or *Wall Street Noise* as both are hilarious. I assume I missed a lot of in-crowd theater jokes and never once fanboyed over Ben Platt or Noah Galvin (instead I am a huge fan of Patti Harrison from *Together, Together* and *I Think You Should Leave*). And yet, the film was still hilarious and heart-warming. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *Hulu*.
29. **Bottoms:** Ayo Edebiri (*Theater Camp*) is a god. She can do anything and make it hilarious. She is amazing as the co-lead and provides constant humor; her ability to turn average dialogue into you laughing up snot is unparalleled. Co-written and directed by Emma Seligman (*Shiva Baby*) it is not as good as her first film as it lacks the cinematic flourishes of the claustrophobic first film. Rachel Sennott (*Shiva Baby*) co-wrote and is the co-lead but brings the least (perhaps because her character is the cause of disagreements, but Sennott is never able to impart the character with any sympathy; again Ayo is a god). The surprise star is Ruby Cruz (*Mare of Easttown*) in their first feature film, she has talent. The surprise star (for people who haven't been paying attention to his career) was Marshawn Lynch (*Murderville*, Not Getting the Ball on the Goal Line in Super Bowl XLIX); him getting an bona-fide role was great to see and he crushed the supportive club adviser, with laughs. At times the high school satire goes a little too far, and it does detract; grounding the film slightly more would have improved it (though by making the male students paper-thin stereotypes it does work as flipping the standard script). [Independent Spirit – Best Screenplay Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

28. **Story Ave:** Even with a standard premise of black-boy-from-the-streets-meets-older-man-wanting-to-help, the film finds new territory with some well-developed characters. The boy is a would-be gangbanger with a recently deceased brother and an aspiring artist. As the film goes on, the view finds his background is unique and does not follow conventions. Luis Guzmán is great as the exhausted MTA worker who befriends and mentors the boy; and again the character's back-story is slowly revealed (Guzmán does some lifting early in the film as his character walks a fine line in earning the kid's trust and is a main reason the film ranks this high). The film avoids most cliches, and is well edited as it progresses through time and place with the viewer picking up on the changes subtly. [ASC – Spotlight Award Nominee].
27. **Blue Jean:** Rosy McEwen (*Vesper*) is absolutely amazing in the film. She carries it and puts in a star-worthy performance. A closeted PE teacher who must deal with life in the UK during a crackdown on homosexuality. The film is often subtle, and even when semi-obvious it always avoids being on-the-nose (watching of *Blind Date* for example). A lot of items are left explicitly unsaid; the reasons for her long commute into work instead of a local school for example. The script is good as it shows the various stages of being out across stages of life; and the costs/benefits that come with the decisions; liberation vs self-preservation being the primary overarching theme. [British Independent Film – Best Lead Performance Winner], *Hulu*.
26. **Saltburn:** Without the final ten minutes, the film would easily be in the next tier (and one could argue they are so bad, it deserved to be ranked a tier lower). Admittedly, I figured out where the film was going very quickly; a nice interpretation would be that the plebs needed the plot (re-)explained. And it is such a sin, if writer-director Emerald Fennell (*Promising Young Woman*) was responsible, she should be required to return her Best Screenplay Oscar. Barry Keoghan (*The Banshees of Inisherin*) is rather good and deserves his round of nominations. The script could also have injected more comedy at times (I did not think Rosamund Pike brought enough haphazardness to her role; partially because of the writing). The movie still ends up being good and thrilling (at times). Take *Parasite* and make it horny. [Critic's Choice – Best Picture Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
25. **Nimona:** Chloë Grace Moretz provides a voice-acting performance for the ages and is able to give her character such depth. The animation is nothing special, multiple films ranked lower have better animation. The strength of the film is the plot; has stuff to say about surveillance states, class, and LGBT issues. It all comes together in a powerful and moving way. It continues Netflix's recent string of revisionist animated films and hopefully Netflix continues producing these films. [Oscar – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
24. **Air:** Ben Affleck and Matt Damon teaming up to make dad-movies for the rest of their lives would be amazing. Affleck directs and does a solid job; really nailing the details of life in 1984. Affleck also plays a supporting role. Damon is rather good; or rather gives a moving speech which helps elevates the film. Jason Bateman plays Jason Bateman and that is always a good thing. The script by Alex Convery is shockingly great; witty, humorous and moving. Viola Davis always has to be mentioned as she is solid as always. This is a fun and well-made movie. [WGA – Best Original Screenplay Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
23. **The Boy and the Heron:** A return to from from Miyazaki (*Spirited Away*); gorgeous hand-drawn animation, an amazing score, a fantasy world (with cute critters), and a child coming of age all with overarching morals. Yet, the film is inferior to his best work, and a little too reminiscent of his earlier work (a lazy review could simply call this a *Spirited Away* remake). In a world where most animation is via computer, it is nice to see an old-school hand-drawn film; even if it becomes harder to show fine details. Backgrounds often look amazing (the 'Great Hall' in the tower being one of the best, another shot of reflections of boats in the water is amazing). The film almost certainly had the best score of the year; composed by Joe Hisaishi. But sadly the film's many themes of grief, war, and innocence do

not fully come together. The film does not end up being hollow, but it is not thematically coherent. Yet, any fan of Miyazaki will enjoy it. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Winner].

Tier 4: Low-End Oscar Nominees (and a Surprise)

22. **Past Lives:** Written and directed by Celine Strong in her debut film. She already has a great visual style. Many shots are well-composed and have good lighting (I am little surprised it didn't get more cinematography recognition; Shabier Kirchner (*Bull*) shot the film). One sequence to highlight is the shot of the train crossing the river (which the characters are presumably on as the previous shot was them on the train) with the camera then panning down to the park and the characters are now walking and talking. It is a gorgeous shot. Greta Lee is amazing in the lead and helps carry the film; most of the film is subtle and requires the actors to convey the necessary emotion; few things are told—only shown. The plot does have a few too many (artistic license) holes, the most egregious being 'let me walk you to your Uber'; Ubers pick you up outside your apartment, there is no need to walk half a block (despite allowing for a beautiful tracking shot). It is a beautiful film about love and relationships, and Celine Strong has set herself up to have an amazing career. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Paramount+*.
21. **No One Will Save You:** At risk of a mild spoiler, I love silent films. There are only a few lines of dialogue in the entire film (and they all occur at once). There are plenty of 'ahhs' and shrieks, but no real lines. It is amazing filmmaking from writer-direct Brian Duffield (*Spontaneous*). A film with no dialogue needs a star to carry it and Kaitlyn Dever is that star. The sci-fi aspect of an alien invasion works, although the film does struggle in the middle; it becomes repeating sequence of Dever's character fighting off that night's/day's alien. Yet once it gets back on track, it fully develops Dever's character with a unique ending after 90 minutes. [Critic's Choice – Best Streaming Film Nominee], *Hulu*.
20. **Maestro:** In forty years when we've forgotten about Bradley Cooper, *Maestro* will be recognized as a top-five film of the year; for now Bradley Cooper is his own worst enemy. Cooper's blatant desire for an Oscar nearly ruins the film; the prosthetic nose, the accent, and I-studied-conducting-for-SIX-YEARS. Which is at odds with the heart of the film; for all the needless realism (nose, accent, etc) all one learns about Leonard Bernstein is that he was a horny bi who chain-smoked. The 'realism' is focused on all the areas one does not need realism; how many Oscar voters could even describe what Bernstein looked liked or sounded like without this film? The first thing the audience thinks is that Bradley Cooper went for stuff that could be said on the campaign trail, rather than developing the character of Bernstein (and his wife). Yet, Bradley Cooper the director is amazing. The lighting in the black-and-white sequences is amazing. Shots are often brilliantly composed (the long shot of the two talking with their faces perfectly positions to be seen through a gate is amazing). The conducting scene is gorgeous and a masterclass. The one-take Thanksgiving parade is amazing. There are so many excellent shots. The directing is why this film should rank higher, and I feel safe in saying in many years it will. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Netflix*.
19. **Barbie:** Is it sexist to say the only reason the film ranks here is Ryan Gosling? That without his all-in fully-committed performance the film would have crumbled under its own weight? Gosling was so good he got Simu Liu to break character. The primary issue with the film is that it is trying to be too much; a serious social commentary and a light-hearted romp for everyone, but by merging these two together the film then becomes tongue-in-cheek in an attempt to keep the balance. In wanting to be for adults (the *2001* and *Singin' in the Rain* homages are nice) and teenage girls, it *almost* ends up for neither. Thankfully the cast is amazing, and a bona fide who's who. The first ten minutes are extremely iffy. The set design was okay, but at times felt like a Wes Anderson rip-off. The costumes were good, but were done better in *Barb & Star* a few years earlier (an *Oppenheimer*-sized

hot take no one is ready for: *Edgar's Prayer* from *Barb & Star* is better than *I'm Just Ken*). Yet, the ending is heart-warming and moving that most sins are forgiven. But unlike many films in this year, *Barbie* was extremely close to be much farther down the list. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *HBOMax*.

18. **Killers of the Flower Moon:** Scorsese's second overly-long prestige picture for a streamer (though this one has a bit longer of a theatrical run, and I saw it in Dolby Cinema). Thankfully this time Scorsese went with a more accurate source material. Leo is rather good, and along with Lily Gladstone (*First Cow*) do the bulk of the heavy lifting; De Niro does not do much for me in this role. The rest of the cast, each in their own bit roles is all wonderful. Yet, for a film that has so much to say about the betrayal and abuse of Natives, the film does not have that much to say. Rather for three hours we see white men perpetuate violence and deny justice to increase their own wealth. Scorsese does an excellent job of moving throughout time (the film covers 10-plus years). Once the plot is figured out, it drags with more instances of violence (the argument is that these murders were done over a long period of time without intervention nor remorse, so there is the need to show it. But just because it took decades to get justice does not mean the audience needs to sit through three-and-a-half hours). And because it is directed by Scorsese, the film is never bad only longer than it needed to be (especially for a director who had perfected murder montages). Perhaps the largest drawback, is that the film is a comment on current (race) relations and politics, without ever overtly saying it (ala a Spike Lee movie). Yet the veneer is too thin and it becomes far too easy to make the connections. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *AppleTV+*.

Tier 3: Really Good Films

17. **Poor Things:** Directed by Yorgos Lanthimos, this is probably his weakest English-language film (the lowest I've had his first three was seventh). The film still maintains his off-beat and dark humor (the script is by Tony McNamara who wrote *The Favourite*). I should mention that the audience in the theater I watched the film in, was not on board with the humor which detracted a little bit. The star of the show is Emma Stone as she plays the character perfectly (and he second film with Lanthimos; they are on the same page concerning comedic delivery). The film does devolve into vignettes (each section has a title card of her current location) that feel a tad disjoint at times. Mark Ruffalo overacts and I am genuinely baffled how he received an Oscar nomination. The cinematography looks good, but features too many fish-eye shots for my liking. The production design is unique and somehow manages to blend Steampunk with the Victorian Era. Jerrod Carmichael (*On the Count of Three*) nearly manages to steal the show from Stone in his few scenes. The film does a great job developing the character of Bella, and has more to say about being a woman than *Barbie*. [Oscars – Best Actress Winner], *Hulu*.
16. **They Cloned Tyrone:** Co-written by Juel Taylor and Tony Rettenmaier (also the co-writers of *Space Jam 2: A New Legacy* (?!)), with Taylor in his directorial debut. The pays a great tribute to classic Blaxploitation films with its visual style (the grainy film stock, and amazing costumes being the most easily noticed). The leading trio of John Boyega (*Breaking*), Teyonah Parris (*Candyman* (2021)), and Jamie Foxx (*Soul*) are all rather good, with both Parris and Foxx providing a lot of excellent comedy (the film as a whole is subtly hilarious). The second half of the film becomes a sci-fi social commentary, and one that is far superior to *Sorry to Bother You*. As *Tyrone* is more subtle and more complex. [Black Reel – Best Screenplay Nominee], *Netflix*.
15. **Oppenheimer:** I was lucky enough to see the film at one of the nineteen theaters in the United States screening the film in 70mm IMAX. The IMAX screen does wonders for the film. The close-ups of characters faces, allows the character to dominate the screen (in a way that is reminiscent of Apple's 1984 commercial). The detail and texture of the faces is amazing. Somehow the landscapes

do not look as good, perhaps because the detail in the close-ups can not be matched. The entire cast is rather good (there are multiple great actors who show up for a single scene and nearly steal the show, but it is best to be surprised by their appearances). The issues with the film all boil down to the now-standard Nolan-isms: the film is far far far too loud (and worst of all, most of the noise is there to be noise; it is not coming from a specific origin; the film is not in Dolby Atmos or other 3D sound format), the film is a tad too long (partially as the film tries to hit on a few too many themes that don't quite all come together), and most plot points are overly spelled out for the audience. These detract from the overall film. [Oscars – Best Picture Winner], *Peacock*.

14. **Sanctuary:** I don't care, I am putting the film here. Some may not like that the film feels like a play; entirely set in a hotel suite (and hallway and elevator) with only two speaking characters. I love these paired-down films. Factor in that the characterization is done almost entirely thru sexual fantasies and fetishes, it has everything I want. More films should explore the depths of sexual fantasies as a form of characterization (look where I have *Infinity Pool* and *Saltburn*). The lighting is often good, and there are a few nice shots; the opening shot looks great and the sequence is a 20-minute masterclass. Margaret Qualley (*Once Upon a Time in Hollywood*) is amazing, Christopher Abbott (*James White*) is also rather good, as both need to be excellent to carry the film given its construct. By being about sex, the film is able to not be about sex and instead showcase insecurities and develop great characters. What is especially interesting is the constant change of who is 'in control' and it constantly flips thru great writing. [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Hulu*.
13. **The Caine Mutiny Court-Martial:** In some ways it is a shame that there is a superior courtroom drama on this list, as that is the most plausible reason why *Caine* was overlooked during awards season; the second-most being a streaming-only release on Showtime. It is a fitting final film from William Friedkin (*The Birthday Party*, *The French Connections*, *Killer Joe*). One does wish the film the cinematic flourishes of *The Birthday Party* (one of his first films and one with essentially one set/location). The script and dialogue are very tight; at almost an hour-and-fifty minutes the film never bogs down. The courtroom stays tense. A reason the tension stays high is the actors are all in top shape: Jason Clarke (*Oppenheimer*), Jake Lacy (*The White Lotus*), Monica Raymund, Lewis Pullman (*The Starling Girl*), and Lance Reddick (*The Wire*) are all part of an amazing ensemble cast (there is a strong argument they deserved a SAG nomination for Best Cast). Kiefer Sutherland (*They Cloned Tyrone* and *Melancholia*) was amazing. He deserved a Best Actor Nomination (Cooper, Wright, and even Domingo were inferior). Especially for a character that Bogart played in the 50s, Sutherland finds a way to make the role his own, and helps carry the film (again, the film does not bog down even when characters give lengthy statements on the witness stand). I have not seen the play (which itself is based on the original 1950s novel) the film is based on, so I am not exactly sure how much is from Friedkin, though he is credited as the sole writer. [Critic's Choice – Best Streaming Film Nominee], *Paramount+*.
12. **Earth Mama:** Written and directed by Savanah Leaf in her directorial debut, and she has instantly established herself as a force. The film is beautifully shot; the camera almost always lingers; either slowly zooming in to enhance the emotion of the actors, or slowly slowly zooming out to reveal the setting. There are multiple amazing tracking shots (the one in the park getting diapers is probably the best and most impactful). There is another shot of The Bay with the sun reflecting off the water, yet as the camera zooms out the 'sun' is actually perfectly placed lens flare and the real sun slowly is revealed to the audience. Jody Lee Lipes (*Manchester by the Sea* and *Martha Marcy May Marlene*) was the cinematographer. Tia Nomore in her acting debut is great in the lead role and plays a caring (and also pregnant) mother who must deal with her previous life choices and poverty. This is a lovely and moving film that went under the radar, but announces that everyone involved will go on to great things. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *Paramount+*.

Tier 2: It Was a Deep Year (and Be Prepared to Cry)

11. **Palm Trees and Power Lines:** An absolute stone cold stunner of a coming-of-age. The crowded sub-genre of teen girls dating older men instantly has a contender for best of the genre (the film even has a nice homage to *An Education*—a personal favorite of mine). The film announces Lily McInerney as a star, she is amazing and able to convey the boredom with her life and why an older man is able to bring excitement at joy. Jonathan Tucker is rather good in a difficult role to play; the man always has difficulty in these as they need to be charming enough to fall in love with but evil enough to cause the inevitable fall out (and the missed red flags). First-time writer and director Jamie Dack has a plot full of foreshadowing and frequently lets the camera linger with long takes. The view is able to figure out the path the film will take (adults are better at spotting red flags than teenagers) but the characters are developed that you still are captivated by the journey. One of the long takes is the film's climax and it is devastatingly beautiful. The epilogue is then one of pure genius. The film might be hard to watch and I won't spoil anything, but if one is fine with the subject matter it is an amazing work of cinema. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee].
10. **The Iron Claw:** Directed by Sean Durkin (*Martha Marcy May Marlene* and *The Nest*), he continues to fly under the radar as a great director (three films in thirteen years might do that). The visuals are really good; the opening black-and-white sequence looks amazing and instantly pulls the viewer into the film. Zac Efron (*High School Musical*) probably deserved a Best Actor nomination. He does a lot of heavy lifting (figuratively and literally) in the film. His subtle expressions convey a lot of meaning, and allow the film to show instead of tell. The rest of the cast is rather good (one wishes the mom, was a little more developed). It is one of the better films about toxic masculinity and family trauma. It is said it flew under the radar due to A24 backing other films during Awards Season. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film], *HBOMax*.
9. **Monica:** Before mentioning the well-written and subtle script, cinematographer Katelin Arizmendi's (*Swallow*, *Charm City Kings*) gorgeous 1.2:1 narrow photography deserves heaps of praise. A scene with the titular Monica holding her mother in the near dark (only backlit by a light in the house) is one of the best shots of the year (that it then cuts to Monica petting the dog the next morning is also amazing), the shot of Monica driving to the bar to meet up with someone also looks great, when he doesn't show and she calls him from outside the green lighting from the neon bar sign makes that shot look amazing. Even without the writing and acting, the film would rank highly because of the cinematography. Andrea Pallaoro's direction and script avoids exposition and requires the viewer to piece a lot of the film together based on context; Trace Lysette's performance as Monica is rather good as her performance needs to convey the emotion. The script requires the performance to convey information and she is beyond up to the task. Although it might start off slow, and take a while to coalesce, it is worth waiting on as the payoff is a tender coming-home film. [Independent Spirit – Best Cinematography Nominee], *Hulu*.
8. **All of Us Strangers:** Written and directed by Andrew Haigh (*Lean on Pete*) in what was one of the best adapted screenplays of the year. Andrew Scott (*Fleabag*) is extremely good and it is sad he didn't garner more acting nominations. Paul Mescal (*Aftersun*) is good in everything and probably the best actor going right now. Both Jamie Bell (*Film Stars Don't Die in Liverpool*) and Claire Foy (*Women Talking*) are also rather good. The script allows for multiple interpretations (again, it is one of the best adaptations of the year). There are multiple expertly composed shots with mirrors. It is an exceptional film on love and loss. [Independent Spirit – Best Film Nominee], *Hulu*.
7. **Godzilla Minus One:** I do not know much Godzilla lore, but this film apparently managed to sneak in lots of easter eggs flawlessly; Odo Island, eating a train, a scientist 'saving' the day, among countless others I probably missed (compared to *Super Mario Bros* which forced the references these felt organic). What makes this film work is that it is *not* a Godzilla film. The best recent horror films use trauma in inventive ways to scare the audience and the characters are not there simply to be killed (or eaten, or atomic breath-ed) but to develop and make peace with their issues. This film

does so perfectly; not only with an individual dealing with their personal ‘failures’ during war but with an actual reckoning with Japan’s action in World War II (the original *Godzilla* very much tried to avoid blaming Japan). The cinematography and visuals are amazing, the sound is also amazing (the inevitable US 4K disc should end up as reference quality). Yet sadly the film can not pull off the ending; a few too many cliches, too much exposition, and one or two plot conveniences. It is still one of the best films of the year and possibly the (second-) best looking of the year. [Oscars – Best Visual Effects Winner].

6. **The Zone of Interest:** Written and directed by Jonathan Glazer (*Under the Skin*). The film might be the best directorial effort of the year. The is gorgeously shot and composed (well, as good as a film can be when the background is literally Auschwitz; it is the real camp in the background, not VFX or matte paintings). Łukasz Żal (*I’m Thinking of Ending Things* and *Cold War*) might be the best cinematographer yet to win an Oscar. Some of the long tracking shots in the garden are exquisite. The night-time shots of the local girl are ingenious. There is an amazing shot of a train entering(?) the camp but all that is seen is the smoke raising above the wall and tracing out the train’s path. It is truly a directorial masterpiece; the film often shows but rarely tells. And, in its best parts, it does not even show; it merely uses sound. The film has such excellent background noise (well, as good as a film can be when the background sound is literally a genocide). The Oscar nomination for Best Sound is beyond deserved. It probably has the best sound of the year. Though the directing achievement is so strong, it sadly leaves its characters and little short. The characters get a fair bit of development, but cant not keep up the sound and visuals. The actors are good; first Sandra Hüller shout-out of the year, but they are never given time to shine. Perhaps Christian Friedel will get is star-turn in the upcoming season of *The White Lotus* which he has been cast in. This is a film that some people could easily put number one for the year and I wouldn’t put up a fight. [Oscars – Best Sound Winner], *HBOMax*.
5. **A Thousand and One:** Written and directed by A.V. Rockwell in her directorial debut. She captures the aesthetic feel of NYC in the mid-90s, and the 00s perfectly (in many ways it feels like a black/inner-city *Leave No Trace*; which is a massive compliment). The star of the picture is Teyana Taylor in the lead role. She received a few nominations, but not enough. She absolutely carries the film. The plot is good, and is slightly dependent on a well-foreshadowed revelation that really brings the the entire plot home and cements the character development during the entire film. The only knock on the film, as you’d expect about a film set in 00s NYC by a black director, it veers off into grievances about gentrification. Remember that gentrification is everywhere and always a result of not building housing. If you hate gentrification, support building more high-rise apartments below 106th. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Winner], *Amazon Prime*.
4. **Spider-Man: Across the Spider-Verse:** The film is not as good as the first (*Into the Spider-Verse*); mainly as a lot of the initial charm from the animation styles and frame rates is gone. If anything the changing styles becomes tiresome in this film. The exception is the watercolors in Gwen Stacy’s universe. Although the new characters often have great voice actors, they also do not have the same enjoy-ability/looniness as the first. Luckily the film still has multiple great jokes. The film excels at expanding the multiverse by adding tons of Easter Eggs and exploring the lore/canon of Spider-Man. At two-hours-twenty it never drags. The franchise is a resounding success and I can not wait for the third film, as a large chunk of the ranking was finding a unique way to continue the story. The film could have been on obvious cash grab, and yet it keeps its core of great animation, great voice acting, and wonderful character development. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.

Tier 1: Best Films of 2023

3. **The Holdovers:** Paul Giamatti puts in the performance of the year as a curmudgeonly ancient history teacher at a prestigious all-boys boarding school. Giamatti plays the well-written character perfectly and maintains a delicate balance; the character is an alcoholic asshole who is always right, but he actually he usually right and he's accepted his loneliness. Even some of his worse impulses are eventually explained through backstory. Giamatti was also equaled by Dominic Sessa *in his first performance*. Sessa could end up being the find of the century, instantly becoming someone to watch. It is a shame he has not received more Best Supporting Actor nominations. Da'Vine Joy Randolph (*Dolemite Is My Name*) is rather good, but her steamrolling the Support Actress awards is a little odd, though the field in the category is weak this year (perhaps because the character could have used a little more development). The cinematography and production design is exquisite (and helped by snowscaped campuses); the film looks like a product of the 1970s (including vintage studio title cards, and in a few cases invented 'vintage' logos). It is beautifully shot film about three people dealing with loss and loneliness. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
2. **Anatomy of a Fall:** Co-written and directed by Justine Triet. Even the though film is a two-hour-thirty-minute courtroom drama it never bogs down and is always thrilling. It is an underappreciated benefit of the film; the script is rather good. Part of the benefit of the script is keeping the mystery up; was the death a murder or an accident, or something else? The mystery is also kept up thru character development; not deus ex machina. Every new revelation is organic or briefly mentioned at the start of the film. Sandra Hüller (*The Zone of Interest*) puts in an absolutely amazing performance, and without her the film probably falls apart; she maintains an air of innocence for her character. The fight scene will be shown for years because of how good she is in it. There is another great scene later in the film, but detailing it would be a spoiler; what makes it great is that the testifying character's dialogue is synced with the lips during the flashback. It has easily established itself as an all-time courtroom drama, even if the French legal system is a bit crazy. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Winner], *Hulu*.
1. **May December:** Natalie Portman (*Black Swan*) puts in a tour de force. It might be the best performance of the year; the make-up scene and the monologue being the two best; the 'actor's studio' being another great moment. Todd Haynes (*Carol* and *Dark Waters*) directed the film, and has somehow flown under my radar, despite directing two of my more-recent favorites; perhaps because he does not have a distinct visual style relative to other well-known directors. Both Julianne Moore (*Still Alice*) and Charles Melton are also rather good. The film slowly unfolds with twists and turns, all with this constant air of doubt over what is the real story; itself acting a meta commentary on filmmaking (Portman plays an actress visiting the person she'll be playing in an attempt to better understand the character). The film has multiple great characters, all of which are fully fleshed out (even if ambiguous or contradictory at times). The score is amazing, but also partially adapted from Joseph Losey's (another underrated director) 1971's *The Go-Between* so I am not sure how much is original. In a year where my list managed to have three films about adults sexually exploiting children, this is the best of them and the year. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Nominee], *Netflix*.